

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · August 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	81.8
#2	A+	Cincinnati	73.9
#3	A+	Charlotte	73.2
#4	A+	Hartford	72.9
#5	A+	Nashville	71.7
#6	A+	Kansas City	70.9
#7	A+	Salt Lake City	68.0

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Louisville	18.7
#49	C-	Chicago	27.2
#48	C-	Grand Rapids	27.6
#47	C-	Detroit	28.5
#46	C-	Sacramento	30.6
#45	C-	Richmond	31.4
#44	C	Indianapolis	34.0

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	12 cities
B+ / B / B-	19 cities
C+ / C / C-	18 cities
D	1 cities

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · August 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	81.8	3.1%	+3.8%	+2.6%	+0.4%	54 days
2	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	73.9	3.9%	+6.4%	+1.1%	+0.1%	40 days
3	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	73.2	3.6%	+4.7%	+1.6%	+0.3%	57 days
4	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	72.9	2.7%	+4.7%	+1.9%	+2.8%	33 days
5	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A+	71.7	3.3%	+6.0%	+1.6%	-0.1%	58 days
6	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	70.9	3.7%	+7.7%	+0.8%	+0.5%	47 days
7	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	68.0	3.6%	+4.2%	+2.7%	+1.0%	54 days
8	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A	65.2	3.5%	+3.1%	+0.4%	+1.9%	56 days
9	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	62.2	4.1%	+4.7%	+1.9%	+1.3%	67 days
10	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	A-	60.7	4.6%	+5.0%	+1.4%	+1.7%	74 days
11	St. Louis St. Louis	A-	60.7	3.8%	+2.0%	+0.4%	+0.7%	44 days
12	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	A-	59.4	4.0%	+0.3%	+1.4%	-0.6%	40 days
13	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B+	58.2	3.8%	+5.6%	+0.1%	+2.5%	50 days
14	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	57.6	5.2%	+4.5%	+2.9%	+0.2%	57 days
15	Memphis Memphis	B+	57.4	4.8%	+9.0%	+0.2%	-1.4%	66 days
16	Columbus Columbus	B+	55.8	3.3%	+3.5%	+0.4%	-0.4%	40 days
17	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	54.7	4.1%	+0.7%	+0.6%	+2.0%	44 days
18	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	51.0	4.7%	+5.6%	+0.2%	+0.5%	72 days
19	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B	50.9	4.0%	+3.9%	-0.4%	+1.2%	39 days
20	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	50.1	5.0%	+6.4%	+0.3%	-1.0%	44 days
21	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B-	49.6	4.4%	+7.2%	+1.1%	-1.3%	45 days
22	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	49.3	4.5%	+2.8%	+0.7%	+1.2%	53 days
23	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B-	49.2	4.2%	+6.2%	+0.6%	-1.6%	39 days
24	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	48.9	3.7%	+0.6%	+1.0%	-0.3%	58 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	47.9	3.4%	-0.3%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
26	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B-	47.4	4.7%	+1.9%	+1.3%	+0.7%	54 days
27	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	45.3	3.9%	+3.2%	+0.4%	+2.9%	46 days
28	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	45.3	4.2%	+5.1%	+0.1%	-0.0%	52 days
29	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	44.9	4.1%	+5.2%	-2.4%	-1.7%	39 days
30	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	44.7	5.0%	+3.6%	+1.8%	-2.2%	52 days
31	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	44.5	3.9%	+2.0%	+0.6%	-2.1%	51 days
32	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	43.9	3.8%	+1.6%	-0.4%	+1.7%	35 days
33	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	41.7	4.0%	+5.9%	-0.6%	-1.1%	39 days
34	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	C+	41.6	3.9%	+6.9%	+0.2%	-0.1%	85 days
35	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	40.8	4.9%	+2.4%	+1.4%	-2.7%	67 days
36	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	40.6	4.3%	+3.0%	+0.6%	+1.7%	38 days
37	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	C+	39.4	5.2%	+1.5%	+1.1%	+0.9%	50 days
38	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C+	39.1	4.8%	-0.7%	+0.3%	+0.8%	63 days
39	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C+	38.6	4.4%	+0.0%	+1.5%	-1.0%	38 days
40	Fresno Fresno	C	36.4	7.7%	+6.0%	+1.6%	-1.7%	55 days
41	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	36.3	5.3%	+6.2%	+0.7%	-1.9%	61 days
42	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	36.0	5.0%	+5.8%	-2.1%	-0.8%	57 days
43	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C	34.0	4.8%	+1.3%	+0.6%	+0.2%	65 days
44	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C	34.0	3.4%	-0.7%	-1.3%	+0.2%	47 days
45	Richmond Richmond	C-	31.4	3.8%	+2.6%	-0.7%	-0.8%	40 days
46	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C-	30.6	4.8%	+1.1%	+0.7%	-1.4%	46 days
47	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	28.5	5.4%	+1.1%	-0.2%	+2.7%	39 days
48	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C-	27.6	4.2%	+2.0%	-0.3%	-8.8%	37 days
49	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	27.2	5.3%	+3.2%	+0.1%	-0.5%	35 days
50	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	D	18.7	5.2%	+1.2%	-0.5%	+0.1%	43 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

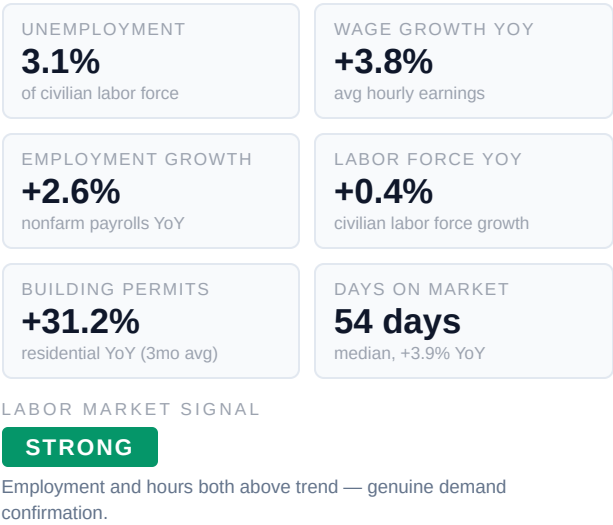
81.8th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 81.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 9.41, and its highly developed office economy, ranking in the 98th percentile. The combination of a 2.64% employment growth rate and a 1.410% weekly hours deviation from trend underscores the city's strong job market.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area boasts a 2.64% employment growth rate and a 1.410% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation, with hours worked above the trend line, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 9.41 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.10%, ranking in the 94th percentile, which indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and wage pressure may be higher. However, this also suggests a strong local economy with a high level of job security.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.78%, ranking in the 52nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. While this is not exceptionally high, it still suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, and worker purchasing power is increasing. This moderate wage growth may help balance the need for businesses to attract and retain talent while managing labor costs.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score ranking in the 86th percentile, with a PSF of \$217/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.84, resulting in a ratio of 5.73. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 2.2% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.37% year-over-year, ranking in the 58th percentile. While this growth rate is not exceptionally high, it still indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, albeit slowly. This moderate growth suggests that businesses may face some challenges in finding new talent, but the overall labor market remains relatively stable.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 31.25% year-over-year, ranking in the 86th percentile. This significant increase suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, the city is likely to remain an attractive location for workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.9%, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market, but one that is still accessible for relocating workers. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a sign of demand erosion.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 98th percentile. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, moderate wage growth, and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent and investment. However, the tight labor market and potential for wage pressure may pose a risk for businesses looking to hire and expand in the area, and decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

73.9th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		48
25% weight		
Unemployment		92
20% weight		
Wage Growth		88
15% weight		
Cost of Living		92
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		48
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		88
10% weight		
Days on Market		88
5% weight		
Office Economy		42
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +47.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 40 days median, +8.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and strong wage growth of +6.37% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest a city with a high demand for labor and increasing worker purchasing power.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +1.08% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.694% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.12, near the median. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as the city is adding jobs, albeit with hours slightly below trend. The labor market is growing, but not at an accelerated pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.90%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and wage pressure is likely to be high. Companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +6.37% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as employees have more disposable income to spend in the local economy. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$192/sqft (decreasing by 0.5% year-over-year) to \$35.18/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.46. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF value is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of +0.14% year-over-year, near the median. This slow expansion of the labor force supply may pose a moderate challenge for hiring, as the pool of available workers is not increasing rapidly. Businesses may need to invest in training and development to attract and retain talent in this market.

Building Permits

Cincinnati has seen a +47.86% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for its workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cincinnati is 40 days, with an 8.1% year-over-year increase, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a suitable home. The rising DOM is a sign of a healthy normalization in the housing market.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's office economy is near the median, with a percentile rank of 42, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that require a mix of industrial, logistics, and office skills, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized tech or finance talent.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of low unemployment, strong wage growth, and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market, which may lead to wage pressure and challenges in hiring, requiring companies to adapt their recruitment and retention strategies to succeed in this market.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A+

EXCELLENT

73.2th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		92
25% weight		
Unemployment		86
20% weight		
Wage Growth		60
15% weight		
Cost of Living		76
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		56
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		40
10% weight		
Days on Market		60
5% weight		
Office Economy		78
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.7% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.3% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -5.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 57 days median, +7.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.2th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 7.47, and its low unemployment rate of 3.60%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of a 1.57% employment growth rate and a 0.970% weekly hours deviation from its own trend suggests genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has seen a 1.57% employment growth rate and a 0.970% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, indicating a strong labor demand. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This suggests that businesses are not only adding jobs but also increasing the workload for existing employees, indicating a healthy and growing economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.60%, which is in the top tier of US metros, ranking 86th percentile. This low unemployment rate indicates a tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this city, it may be challenging to find available talent, and they may need to offer competitive salaries to attract workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 4.70%, which is above average, ranking 60th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. At the same time, workers are seeing an increase in their purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a cost of living score that ranks 76th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. With a PSF of \$220/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$38.03/hr, the ratio of 5.78 is relatively low, especially considering that PSF is falling by 0.5% year-over-year. This makes the city an attractive location for talent, as workers can afford a relatively high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is growing at a rate of 0.33% year-over-year, which is near the median of US metros, ranking 56th percentile. While this growth rate is not exceptionally high, it still indicates that the workforce supply is expanding,

providing a modest increase in hiring capacity for businesses.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has decreased by 5.10% year-over-year, ranking 40th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding as quickly as demand, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is currently 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.5%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a suitable home. However, this trend also suggests that the market may be normalizing after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking 78th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. On the other hand, the city may be less suitable for industries that rely heavily on industrial or logistics workers.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, a talented workforce, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability issues and housing supply constraints, which may impact the city's ability to attract and retain top talent.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

72.9th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 72.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.70% and its strong labor demand composite score of 6.34, which ranks in the 84th percentile. The combination of a high employment growth rate and low unemployment suggests a highly competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.593% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, indicating a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, which is extremely low and indicates a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and wage pressure is likely to be high. With an unemployment rate ranking in the 98th percentile, this market has very little slack.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +4.73%, which is above average and ranks in the 62nd percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but they can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living score that ranks in the 35th percentile, with a PSF of \$253/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$39.99/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.33. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is increasing by 4.1% year-over-year further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, which is a very positive sign for businesses looking to hire. This expanding labor force supply suggests that the city has a strong pipeline of potential workers, making it

easier for companies to find the talent they need. With a labor force growth rate ranking in the 96th percentile, this city is well-positioned for future hiring needs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is increasing by +18.05% year-over-year, which is a strong indicator of developer confidence and a growing housing supply. This expansion of housing stock is likely to improve affordability and make the city more attractive to relocating workers. With a building permits growth rate ranking in the 78th percentile, the city is poised for future growth and development.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.9%. This suggests a highly competitive and fast-paced housing market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The low days on market ranking in the 4th percentile indicates a very hot market, which can be a constraint for businesses looking to attract talent from outside the area.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a professional and office worker share that ranks in the 40th percentile, with a composite score of 2.14. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, it may not be the best fit for companies requiring a large pool of industrial or logistics workers.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive and growing labor market, with a strong pipeline of potential workers and a moderate to fast pace of wage growth. However, the city's low unemployment rate and relatively high cost of living may pose significant challenges for businesses looking to hire and attract talent, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating this location.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A+

EXCELLENT

71.7th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		86
Unemployment 20% weight		86
Wage Growth 15% weight		82
Cost of Living 12% weight		65
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		40
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		40
Days on Market 5% weight		44
Office Economy 3% weight		88

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.3% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -5.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 58 days median, +5.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 71.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with an 86th percentile ranking, and its strong wage growth, at +5.97% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a robust job market and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

Nashville's employment growth rate is +1.56% year-over-year, combined with a -0.141% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly fewer hours than trend, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate is 3.30%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate translates to more competition for available talent and potential upward pressure on wages. In practical terms, companies looking to hire in Nashville may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top candidates.

Wage Growth

Nashville is experiencing strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of +5.97% in average hourly earnings, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in Nashville.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$260/sqft to \$35.48/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of -0.8% in PSF, Nashville ranks in the 65th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability, enhancing the city's appeal for businesses and workers alike.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This slight contraction in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is not expanding. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract and retain talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The city is experiencing a -5.10% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may need to factor in potential housing costs and availability when considering relocation or expansion in Nashville.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Nashville is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.5%. This indicates a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. The rising days on market may signal a healthy normalization of the housing market, but businesses should still consider the potential impact on relocating employees.

Office Economy

Nashville has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy talent. Conversely, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Nashville offers businesses a robust job market, strong wage growth, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent and investment. However, the city's tightening housing supply and slight contraction in labor force growth pose potential risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Nashville as a business location.

Kansas City

Kansas City

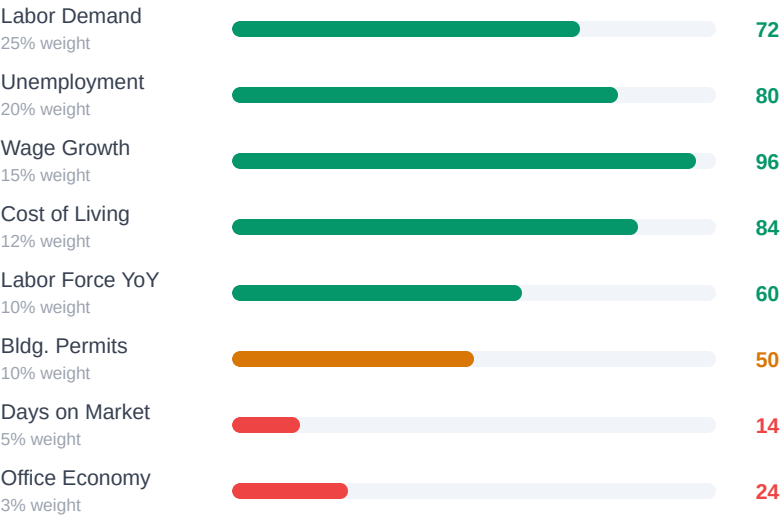
A+

EXCELLENT

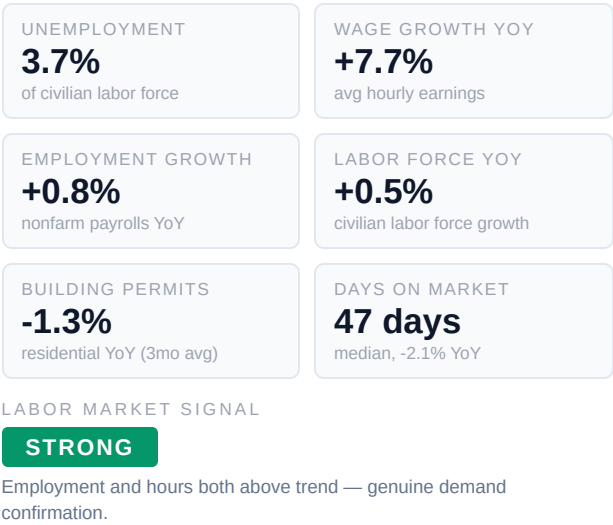
70.9th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.77, and top-tier wage growth of 7.70% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and rising earnings.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is 0.84% year-over-year, combined with a 0.296% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The labor demand composite score of 5.77 further reinforces this trend, ranking in the 72nd percentile.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate is 3.70%, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Kansas City's year-over-year wage growth is 7.70%, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as earnings are increasing rapidly, but may pose challenges for businesses looking to control labor costs. The high wage growth rate suggests that the city's workforce is experiencing significant gains in earnings.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$197/sqft to \$35.67/hr, Kansas City ranks in the 84th percentile, indicating a relatively affordable city compared to its peers. The PSF is rising 2.1% year-over-year, but the high percentile rank suggests that the city remains an attractive option for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can help businesses attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The city's civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.50% year-over-year, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This moderate growth rate suggests that hiring capacity is increasing, but may not be sufficient to meet rapid demand. Businesses may need to plan carefully to ensure they can attract and retain the talent they need.

Building Permits

Kansas City's residential building permits are declining 1.26% year-over-year, ranking near the median, indicating a potential tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits may signal future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. Businesses should consider the potential impact on their workers' ability to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 47 days, with a year-over-year decline of 2.1%, ranking in the 14th percentile, indicating a highly competitive market. This fast-paced market may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, as homes are selling quickly. Businesses may need to provide relocation assistance or support to help their employees navigate the competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share ranks in the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. The city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more attractive to industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a strong labor market with rising earnings and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive option for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's tight labor market and competitive housing market pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and accommodate their workers, and the single biggest risk is the potential for future affordability constraints due to declining building permits.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

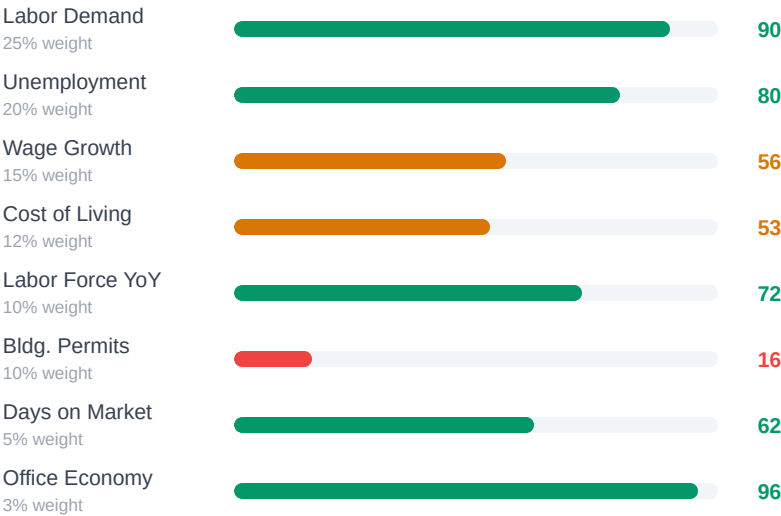
A+

EXCELLENT

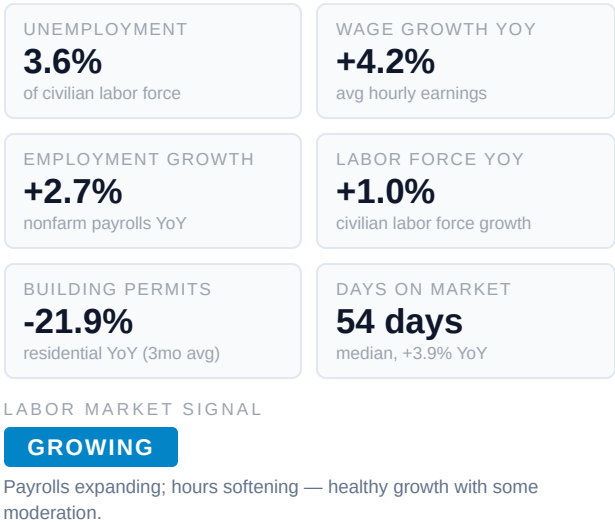
68.0th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.0th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 90th percentile, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 96th percentile for office and professional worker share. The labor demand is driven by a 2.73% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.912% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.73% employment growth rate and a -0.912% deviation in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend despite job growth. This indicates that the labor market is experiencing organic growth rather than a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 7.21 further supports this assessment, placing it in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.60%, which is in the top tier, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The 80th percentile rank for unemployment suggests that the market has some slack but is generally favorable for employers looking for skilled workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is +4.19%, which is near the median, suggesting moderate wage growth. This rate indicates that labor costs for employers are rising but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. The 56th percentile rank for wage growth suggests that the city is experiencing average wage pressure.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$265/sqft to \$38.98/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.80, and a percentile rank of 53rd, Salt Lake City-Murray is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is increasing by 1.1% year-over-year relative to wages suggests that the city is becoming slightly less affordable. However, its current ranking indicates that it does not require significant wage premiums to attract talent, making it relatively competitive.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is growing at a rate of +0.96% year-over-year, which is above average, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is improving, as there are more potential workers

available. The 72nd percentile rank for labor force growth supports this positive outlook.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -21.89%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This sharp decline signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The 16th percentile rank for building permits is a concern for businesses considering relocation, as it may impact their ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.9%. This suggests a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find suitable housing. The 62nd percentile rank for days on market indicates that the city's housing market is becoming more accessible for buyers.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked in the 96th percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray has a very deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, as they can tap into a skilled and specialized workforce. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a deep professional talent pool, and moderate wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

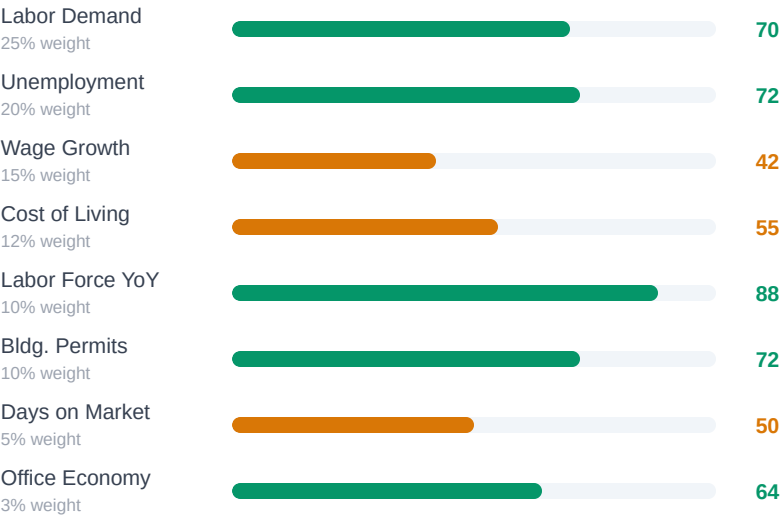
A

VERY GOOD

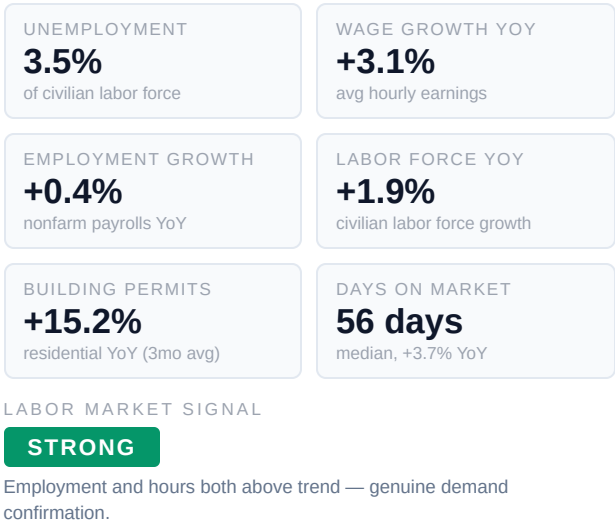
65.2th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and labor force growth being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, at 70th and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.66 and labor force growth rate of +1.93% YoY signal a thriving economy. With an employment growth rate of +0.41% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.789%, Atlanta's economy is characterized by genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.41% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.789% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than the 12-month trend, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.66, at the 70th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.50% is relatively low, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.15% is near the median, ranking in the 42nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and workers have some, but not exceptional, purchasing power. The moderate wage growth may help attract and retain workers without breaking the bank for employers.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 5.37, based on \$197/sqft and \$36.71/hr, and a percentile rank of 55th, Atlanta is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability, combined with a stable PSF YoY change of +0.0%, makes the city an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The affordable cost of living can be a major draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.93% YoY, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a strong pipeline of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The growing labor force can help support business growth and expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +15.16%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. The expanding housing supply can help support the growing labor force.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.7%, ranking in the 50th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor excessively slow, making it accessible for workers relocating to the city. The moderate days on market can provide a healthy environment for businesses to attract and retain workers.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.06, ranking in the 64th percentile, Atlanta has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's professional talent pool is above average, making it an attractive location for businesses in these sectors. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, growing workforce, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the tight labor market and moderate wage growth may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and retain workers. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for rising labor costs and increased competition for talent in a tight market.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A-

GOOD

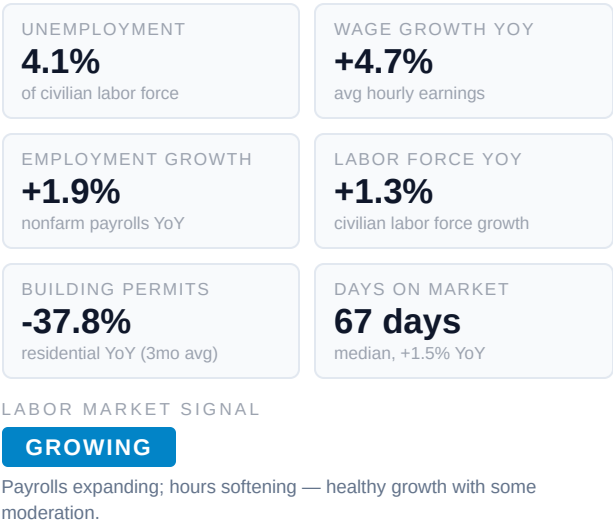
62.2th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 88th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 96th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.89% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.596% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.89% and the -0.596% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend signal a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a healthy increase in jobs without overburdening existing workers. The labor demand composite score of 6.35 further supports this interpretation, placing it in the top tier at the 88th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.10% indicates a market with some slack, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may find it slightly easier to staff than in tighter markets, but may also face weaker local consumer demand due to the relatively higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.74% is above average, ranking at the 64th percentile. This signals moderate to fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but also increasing worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 96th, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is highly affordable relative to its peers, driven by a PSF of \$234/sqft that has decreased by 8.6% year-over-year, combined with an average hourly earnings of \$37.55/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.23. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force has grown by 1.27% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the labor pool is increasing.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -37.80%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This signals a potential future affordability and workforce accommodation challenge, as the tightening housing supply may lead to increased costs and reduced attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 67 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.5%. This suggests a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find a suitable home. However, the below-average percentile rank of 22nd indicates that the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 4.22, ranking at the 94th percentile, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a deep and specialized talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the sharp decline in residential building permits, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, potentially offsetting some of the city's current advantages.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

A-

GOOD

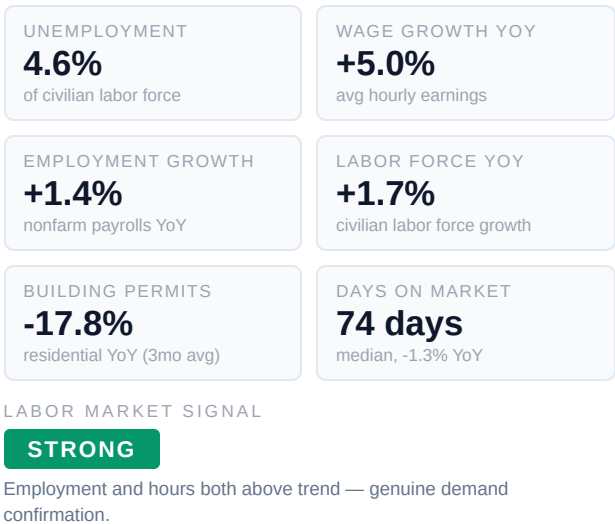
60.7th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 60.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, and its high share of office and professional workers, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. Specifically, the labor demand is driven by a 1.39% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.025% deviation in weekly hours above the city's own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.39% employment growth rate and a 0.025% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area. This indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above the normal trend, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.27 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.60%, which is below average, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may be easier to find candidates, the market is not so loose that it would lead to significant downward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 5.04%, which is above average, ranking in the 66th percentile. This rate of wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. The implication for businesses is that they need to factor in higher labor costs, but the growing consumer demand can also present opportunities.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is relatively affordable, with a cost of living percentile rank in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. The city's PSF (price per square foot) is \$223, and it has decreased by 3.0% year-over-year, compared to an hourly wage of \$33.41, resulting in a ratio of 6.67. This affordability is a significant advantage for talent attraction, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 1.74% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. The implication is that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is -17.79%, which is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile. This decline suggests that the housing supply is not expanding as quickly as demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation. This could signal a tightening in the housing market, which might impact the city's attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 74 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.3%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, although not extremely competitive, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. For a worker relocating to this city, the housing market is accessible, but the trend suggests it might be becoming slightly more competitive.

Office Economy

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share composite ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, it may be less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool of professional workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the decline in residential building permits, which could lead to future housing affordability issues and impact the city's ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce.

St. Louis

St. Louis

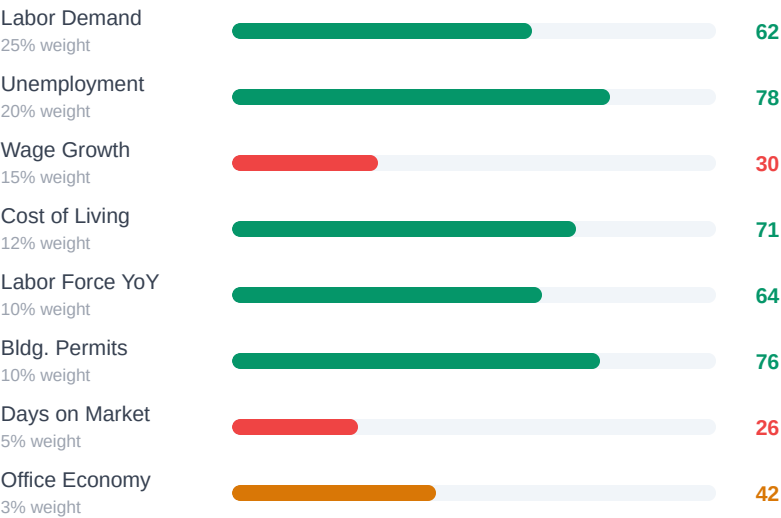
A-

GOOD

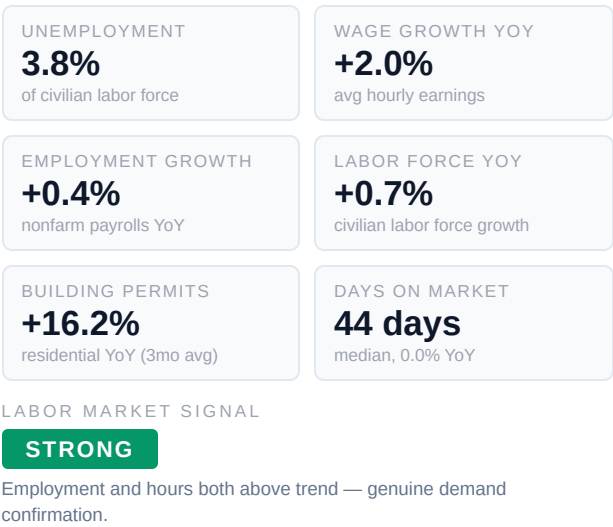
60.7th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it 60.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its above-average labor demand, driven by a 0.44% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.672% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, as well as its relatively low unemployment rate of 3.80%, which ranks in the 78th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with genuine demand expansion and a tight labor market.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 0.44% employment growth rate and a 0.672% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in St. Louis. This indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.59 ranks in the 62nd percentile, further supporting the notion of a thriving labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.80%, ranking in the 78th percentile, which indicates a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power, potentially driving up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in St. Louis is 2.03%, which ranks in the 30th percentile, indicating moderate to slow wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers may not be rising as quickly as in other cities, but worker purchasing power may also be limited. The relatively slow wage growth may make it easier for businesses to manage labor costs, but it may also limit the attractiveness of the city to workers seeking higher-paying opportunities.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living percentile rank of 71, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. The city's PSF of \$164/sqft, which has decreased by 0.6% year-over-year, combined with an average hourly wage of \$37.27, results in a ratio of 4.40, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate without having to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs. The affordability of the city can be a major talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of 0.69% year-over-year, which ranks in the 64th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and

expand their operations. The increasing labor force can help support business growth and reduce the risk of labor shortages.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in St. Louis has increased by 16.20% year-over-year, ranking in the 76th percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, which can lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for workers. The growing housing supply can help accommodate a growing workforce and support business expansion.

Days on Market

The median days on market in St. Louis is 44 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking in the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The competitive market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

St. Louis has an office economy percentile rank of 42, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. The city's share of professional and office workers is 2.18, suggesting that it is suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized knowledge workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a very deep talent pool or those that are heavily industrial or logistics-dominant.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor market, relatively low unemployment, and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the city's relatively slow wage growth and competitive housing market may pose challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent, and decision-makers should factor these constraints into their location decisions.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

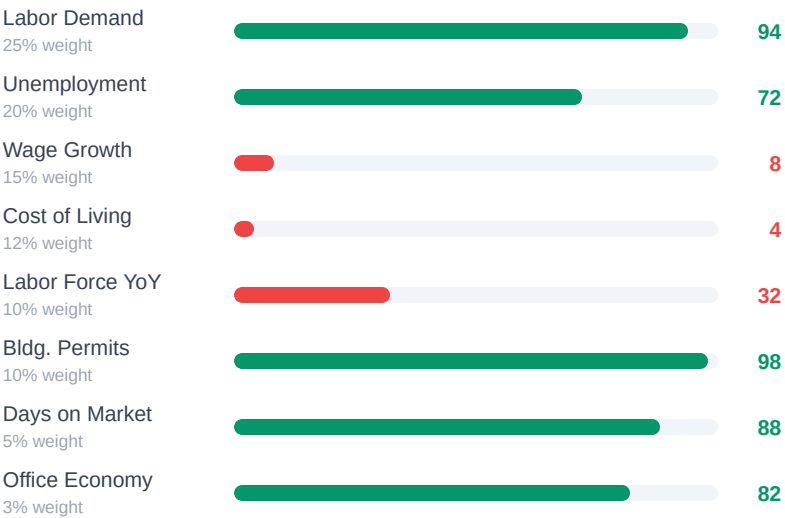
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GOOD

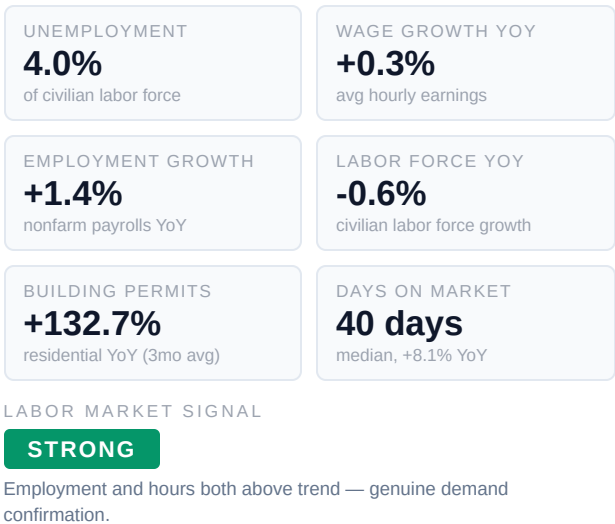
59.4th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 59.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier percentile rank of 94th, and its extremely high cost of living, ranked at the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.44% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 1.369% above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours worked above the historical baseline. The labor demand composite score of 7.69 further reinforces this trend, indicating a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.00%, ranking at the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 0.27%, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers may not have strong bargaining power or increasing purchasing power. The slow wage growth may be a concern for businesses that rely on a highly skilled and motivated workforce.

Cost of Living

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a cost of living ratio of \$797/sqft to \$53.33/hr, with a year-over-year decrease of 3.6% in PSF, ranking at the 4th percentile. This indicates that the city is extremely expensive relative to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums. The high cost of living may be a major constraint for businesses considering relocation to this area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is shrinking at a rate of -0.60% year-over-year, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply may create structural headwinds for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. The

shrinking labor force may also lead to increased competition for workers, driving up wages and labor costs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area has increased by 132.71% year-over-year, ranking at the 98th percentile. This rapid expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, indicating that the city is investing in its infrastructure to support growing demand. The increase in building permits may help to alleviate some of the pressure on the housing market and make it more accessible to relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.1%, ranking at the 88th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the area. The slower market may give buyers more negotiating power and time to find the right home, reducing some of the stress associated with relocating to a new city.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.40, ranking at the 82nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on highly skilled and specialized workers. The city's strong office economy is a major advantage for businesses that need to tap into a talented and knowledgeable workforce.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and a growing housing supply. However, the extremely high cost of living and stagnant wage growth are major concerns that businesses should factor into their decision-making process, as they may need to offer significant wage premiums to attract and retain talent in this competitive market.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

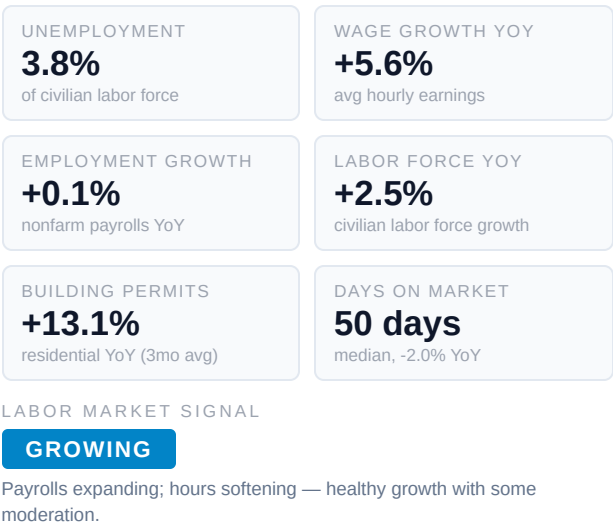
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.2th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.2th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.80% and its above-average wage growth of 5.61% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a tight labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is 0.06% year-over-year, and its weekly hours are deviating -0.272% from its own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.11, which ranks below average at the 26th percentile. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend despite modest job growth. This may indicate some level of survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.80%, ranking at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to upward pressure on wages. With such a low unemployment rate, hiring may be challenging, and companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract workers.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh's year-over-year wage growth is 5.61%, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This fast wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. As wages continue to rise, businesses may need to adjust their budgets to accommodate higher labor expenses, while workers will enjoy increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$174/sqft to \$32.99/hr, Pittsburgh ranks near the median at the 51st percentile. This means the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The cost of living is not a significant advantage or disadvantage for talent attraction, as the ratio is close to average, and PSF is rising 1.8% year-over-year relative to wages.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 2.55% year-over-year, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. As the labor force grows, companies will have access to a larger pool of potential workers, making it easier to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

Pittsburgh has seen a 13.14% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As more housing units become available, the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.0%. This ranks at the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. For workers relocating to this city, the fast-selling market may make it challenging to find a home, as properties are not staying on the market for long.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 36th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in professional sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent. However, the city may still be attractive to businesses in other industries, such as manufacturing or logistics.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of low unemployment, fast wage growth, and an expanding labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and grow. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and fast-paced housing market may pose challenges for relocating workers, and the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for rising labor costs and competition for talent in a tight labor market.

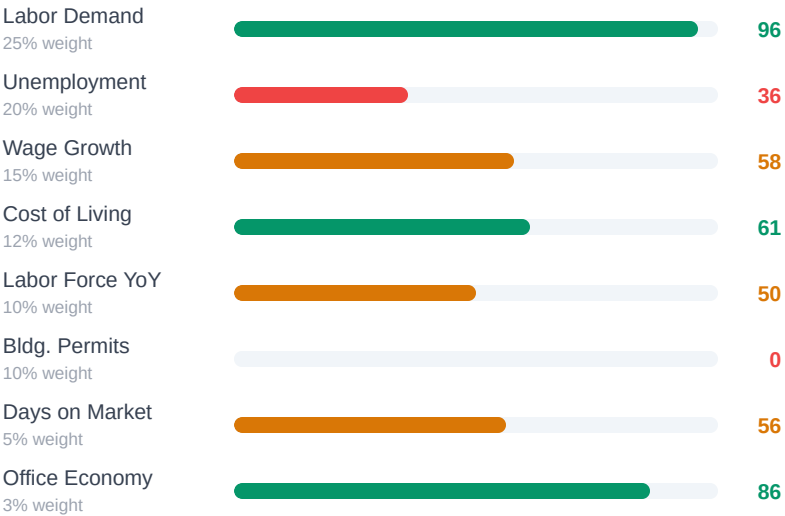
Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

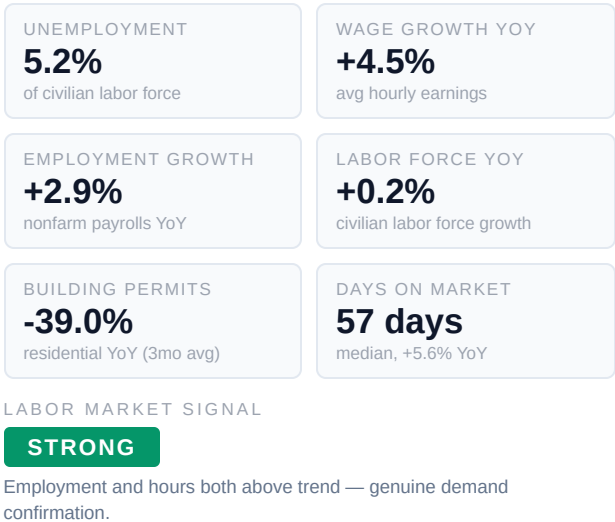
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.6th percentile
Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 57.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 96th percentile, driven by a 2.93% employment growth rate and a 0.171% weekly hours deviation above its own trend. The combination of strong employment growth and above-trend hours worked signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is experiencing a significant labor demand expansion, with a 2.93% employment growth rate and a 0.171% weekly hours deviation above its own trend. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs at a rapid pace and workers are putting in more hours than usual, signaling a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 8.57 ranks in the top tier at the 96th percentile, confirming the city's robust labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas stands at 5.20%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers compared to tighter markets. However, the unemployment rate is not so low that it would drive up wages significantly, providing a moderate environment for hiring.

Wage Growth

The city's wage growth is moderate, with a year-over-year increase of 4.53% in hourly earnings, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This rate of wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are seeing a decent increase in their purchasing power. The moderate wage growth suggests a balanced labor market where neither employers nor workers have excessive bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a cost of living that is above average, with a ratio of \$262 per square foot to \$33.03 per hour, but it ranks in the 61st percentile in terms of affordability. The fact that the PSF is falling by 2.2% year-over-year relative to wages is a key driver of its above-average affordability score. This means the city has a talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums, as the cost of living, although not the lowest, is manageable compared to peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of 0.22% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 50th percentile. This slow but positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit gradually, providing a modest

increase in the hiring capacity for businesses.

Building Permits

The city has seen a significant decline in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of -38.98%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile. This sharp decrease signals that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.6%. This indicates a moderate pace of home sales, neither extremely fast nor slow, suggesting a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city. The near-median percentile rank of 56th percentile confirms that the housing market is not overly competitive, providing a balanced environment for both buyers and sellers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is significant, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, moderate wage growth, and an above-average but manageable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which signals potential future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, making it crucial to monitor and plan for housing supply and affordability in the long term.

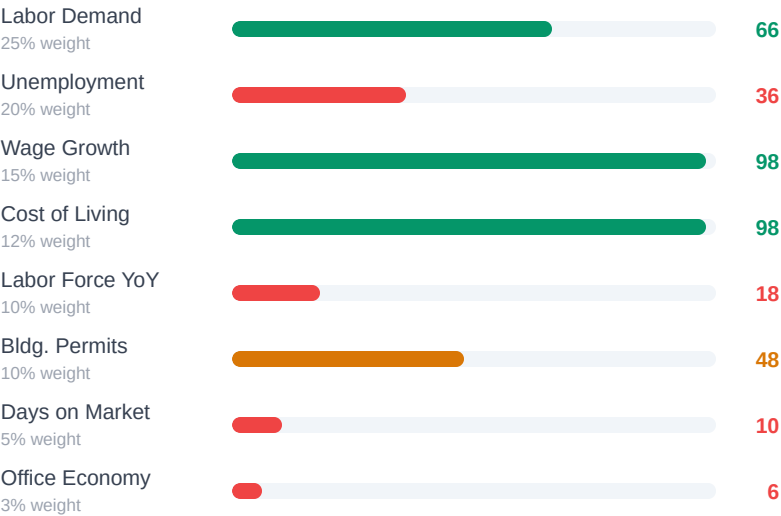
Memphis

Memphis

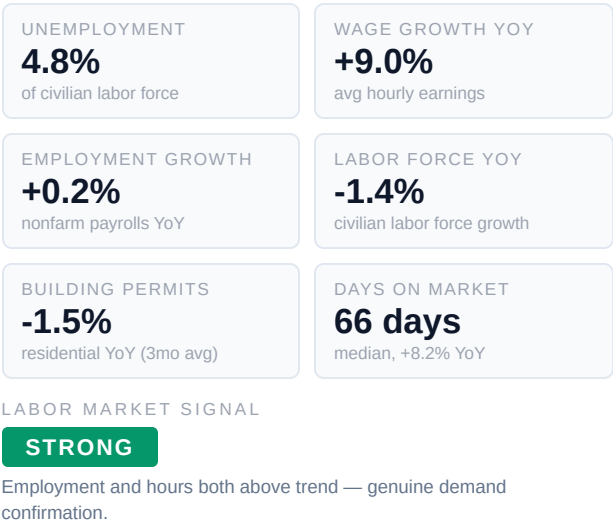
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.4th percentile
Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Memphis has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 57.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally high wage growth rate of 9.02% year-over-year and its very affordable cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$154/sqft to \$33.59/hr, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. The combination of these two metrics suggests a city with strong labor market dynamics and attractive affordability.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of 0.22% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.041% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.65 ranks in the above-average 66th percentile, further supporting the notion of a strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.80%, which ranks in the below-average 36th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may be easier to find candidates, the quality of talent might vary.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 9.02%, Memphis is experiencing very fast wage growth, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for increased labor costs when considering locating in Memphis.

Cost of Living

Memphis has a cost of living that ranks in the top tier at the 98th percentile, making it very affordable relative to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$154/sqft to \$33.59/hr, with PSF decreasing by 6.1% year-over-year, which enhances affordability. This means that Memphis has a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a high quality of life without necessitating wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking at a rate of -1.37% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should consider this constraint when planning for future workforce needs.

Building Permits

Memphis has experienced a -1.49% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This slight decrease in permits suggests that housing supply is not expanding significantly, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Memphis is 66 days, with an 8.2% year-over-year increase, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast market where homes sell quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising DOM could also signal a normalization of the market.

Office Economy

Memphis has a professional and office worker share that ranks in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that Memphis is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but might be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an attractive combination of high wage growth, very affordable cost of living, and a relatively loose labor market, making it an appealing location for certain types of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the shrinking labor force, which poses a significant challenge for future hiring and workforce expansion plans.

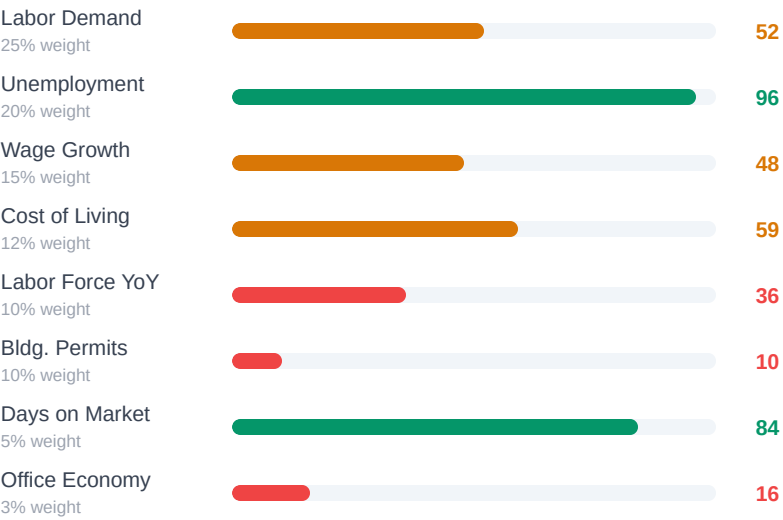
Columbus

Columbus

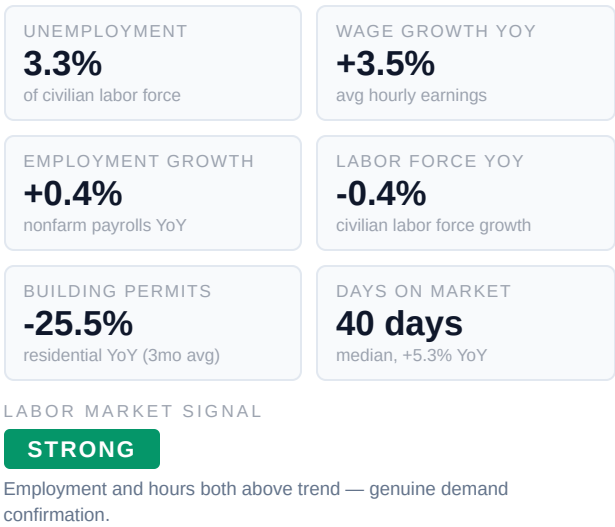
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
55.8th percentile
Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 55.8th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and its sluggish labor force growth rate of -0.43% YoY. These metrics suggest a tight labor market with limited workforce expansion.

Labor Demand

Columbus has an employment growth rate of +0.44% YoY and a weekly hours deviation of +0.246% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.16. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The city's labor market is adding jobs and hours are running above trend, indicating a healthy demand for labor.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 3.30%, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure and competition for talent. As a result, companies may need to offer higher salaries to attract and retain workers.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Columbus is +3.49% YoY, ranking it near the median at the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. Workers in Columbus are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living ratio of \$207/sqft to \$34.31/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.03, which ranks it near the median at the 59th percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The stable PSF YoY change suggests that Columbus can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -0.43% YoY, ranking it below average at the 36th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit new talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Columbus has decreased by -25.53% YoY, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which can lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Columbus is 40 days, with a YoY increase of +5.3%, ranking it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to Columbus may have an easier time finding a home, as properties are sitting on the market for longer periods.

Office Economy

Columbus has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This makes it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a business a relatively affordable location with a tight labor market and moderate wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which can pose significant challenges for hiring and accommodating a growing workforce.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B

AVERAGE

54.7th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		68
Unemployment 20% weight		72
Wage Growth 15% weight		12
Cost of Living 12% weight		24
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		90
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		68
Days on Market 5% weight		26
Office Economy 3% weight		50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +0.7% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +2.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +14.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 44 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and labor force growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.65, combining a +0.61% employment growth rate and a +0.496% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the +2.00% labor force growth rate highlights an expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.61% and weekly hours deviation of +0.496% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a period of growth, with employers adding jobs and workers putting in more hours. The labor demand composite score of 5.65, ranking in the 68th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.10% ranks in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.68% is relatively slow, ranking in the 12th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers have limited bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the purchasing power to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Philadelphia, with a PSF of \$231/sqft and an hourly wage of \$32.52, resulting in a ratio of 7.10, ranks in the 24th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. This means that the city may not have a talent attraction advantage, as workers may require wage premiums to afford the cost of living. The fact that PSF is not falling YoY further contributes to the city's lower affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.00% year-over-year, ranking in the 90th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This means that businesses have a growing pool of potential employees to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff new

positions.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +14.19%, ranking in the 68th percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 44 days, with a YoY direction of +0.0%, ranking in the 26th percentile. This means that homes are selling relatively quickly, making it a competitive market for relocating workers. However, the stable YoY direction suggests that the market is not becoming significantly more or less competitive.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.58, ranking in the 50th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This makes the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less suited for industries with limited office-based roles.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and expand. However, the relatively tight labor market and slow wage growth may pose challenges for businesses trying to attract and retain talent, making it essential to consider these factors in location decisions.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

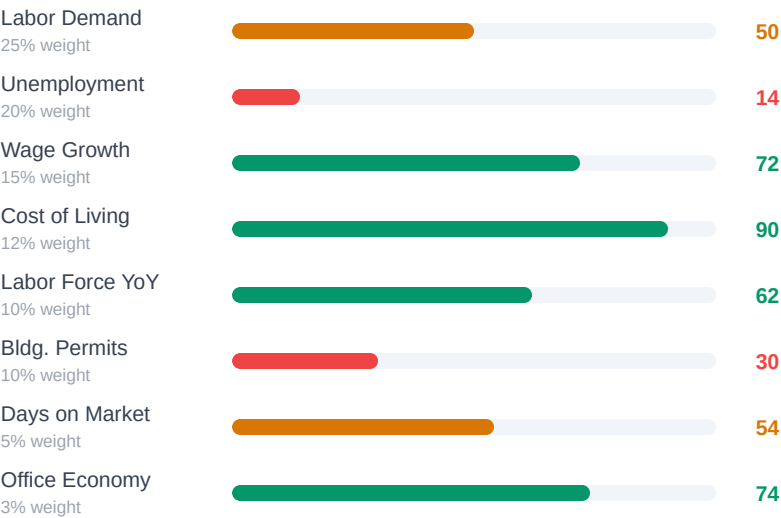
B

AVERAGE

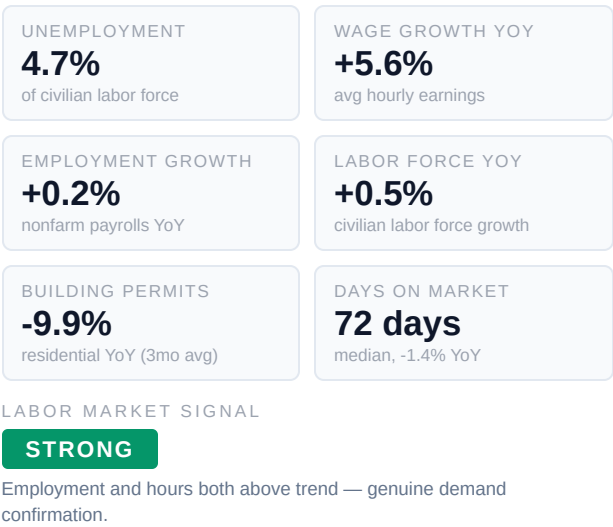
51.0th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 51.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average wage growth and highly affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by a wage growth rate of +5.58% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of \$236/sqft to \$37.30/hr, resulting in a top-tier affordability score. These metrics suggest a city with a strong labor market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +0.23% year-over-year, combined with a +0.504% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score of 5.13. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The city's labor market is growing, but not at an accelerated rate.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, as there is less competition for talent. However, the looser labor market may also contribute to weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is +5.58%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of \$236/sqft to \$37.30/hr, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.8% in PSF, resulting in a top-tier affordability score at the 90th percentile. This means that the city is highly affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring wage premiums. The falling PSF is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of +0.52% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This expanding labor force supply implies that businesses will have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from. The city's labor market is likely to remain dynamic and competitive.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is -9.95%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 72 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.4%. This relatively fast market means that workers relocating to the city may face competition for housing, making it a less accessible market for newcomers.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a professional and office worker share of 3.20, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less ideal for industrial or logistics-dominant operations.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, highly affordable living costs, and a growing labor force. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

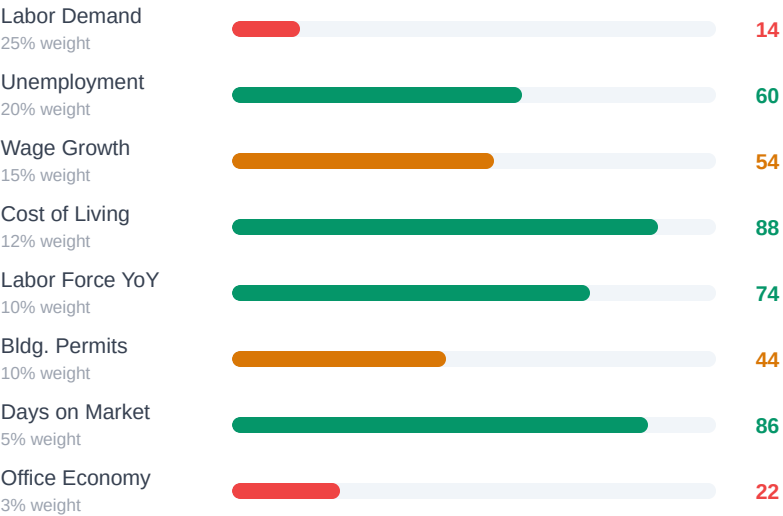
B

AVERAGE

50.9th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 50.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its cost of living and labor force growth. The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$216/sqft and a ratio of 5.84 to hourly earnings of \$36.97, ranks in the 88th percentile, indicating a highly affordable environment. Additionally, the labor force growth rate of 1.23% YoY suggests an expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.37% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.648% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.78, which ranks in the bottom tier (14th percentile). This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.00%, ranking in the 60th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that while it may be slightly easier to find talent than in tighter markets, there is still some competition for workers, and wage pressure may be moderate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +3.93%, ranking near the median (54th percentile), indicating moderate wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising at a moderate pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not at an exceptionally fast rate. As a result, businesses may need to balance wage increases with productivity gains to maintain profitability.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living ratio of 5.84, with a PSF of \$216/sqft (decreasing by 2.3% YoY) relative to hourly earnings of \$36.97, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a highly affordable environment. This means that the city has a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of 1.23% YoY, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This implies that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. As a result, the city's labor force growth is a positive factor for businesses considering relocation or expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is decreasing by 2.81% YoY, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of rising housing costs on their employees' quality of life and affordability.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 39 days, with a YoY increase of 5.4%, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a slower market. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is relatively accessible, with homes taking longer to sell, giving buyers more time to find the right property.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy percentile rank of 22, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This means that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a highly affordable cost of living and an expanding labor force supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the city's labor demand contraction and tightening housing supply are significant risks that decision-makers should factor into their location decisions, as they may impact the availability and affordability of talent and housing in the future.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

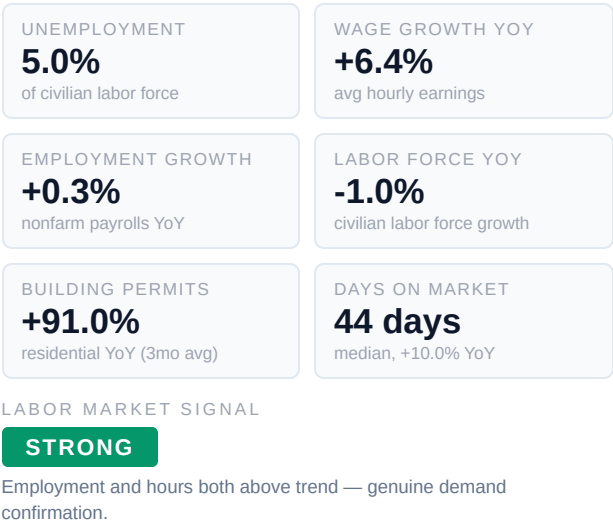
50.1th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 6.37% year-over-year and its significant increase in building permits, up 91.03% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy and increasing housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.27% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.048% above its own trend, indicating a moderate labor demand expansion. This combination signals genuine demand for labor, although at a slower pace than many other metros. The labor demand composite score of 4.73 places the city in the 38th percentile, below average.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.00%, placing it in the 20th percentile, which means the market has some slack. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still competition for talent, and businesses may face some wage pressure. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may need to offer competitive wages to attract the right candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 6.37%, ranking in the 88th percentile, which is considered fast. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also means workers have strong purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living ratio of \$438/sqft to \$47.26/hr, with the price per square foot decreasing by 2.2% year-over-year, placing it in the 39th percentile. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains below average.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is shrinking at a rate of -0.96% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding the right talent due to this shrinking labor force.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has increased by 91.03% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This significant increase suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.0%, placing it in the 92nd percentile. This means the market is relatively slow, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this also indicates a less competitive market for sellers.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 72nd percentile for its share of office and professional workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living and shrinking labor force, which could impact hiring capacity and labor costs.

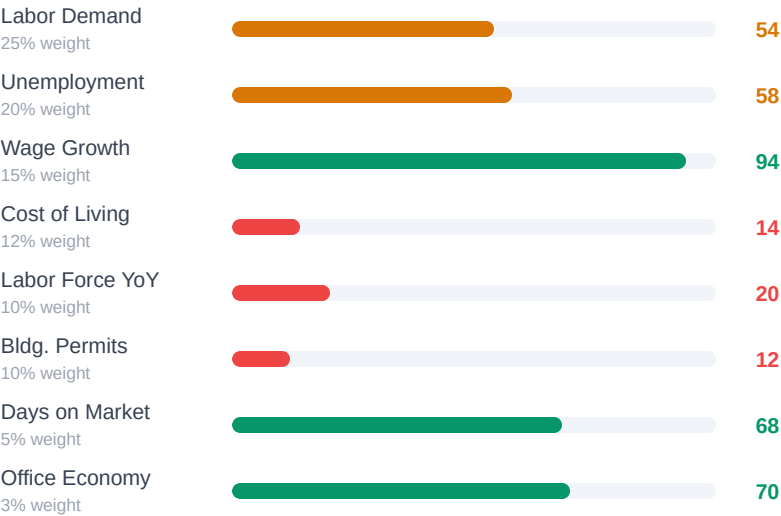
San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.6th percentile
Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 49.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.20% year-over-year and its low cost of living affordability score, ranking at the 14th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 1.07% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.558% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, as the job market is growing, but hours worked are slightly below trend. This suggests that while there is some genuine demand for labor, it is not as strong as it could be.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.40%, ranking at the 58th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.20%, ranking at the 94th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals a strong labor market with rising labor costs for employers. However, it also means that workers have increased purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score ranking at the 14th percentile, with a PSF of \$600/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$43.09/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.92. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. As a result, businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, which can increase labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit new employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has decreased by 23.29% year-over-year. This sharp decline in building permits signals a tightening housing supply, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for

housing. This may make it more difficult for businesses to attract and retain workers who are relocating to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%. This relatively slow market means that homes are sitting on the market for a longer period, making it more accessible for workers to find and purchase homes. However, this may also indicate a slowing demand for housing.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 70th percentile, with a composite score of 3.16 out of 5. This indicates a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city well-suited for tech, finance, and consulting businesses. However, it may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a relatively tight labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the city's low affordability and tightening housing supply, which can increase labor costs and make it challenging to attract and retain workers.

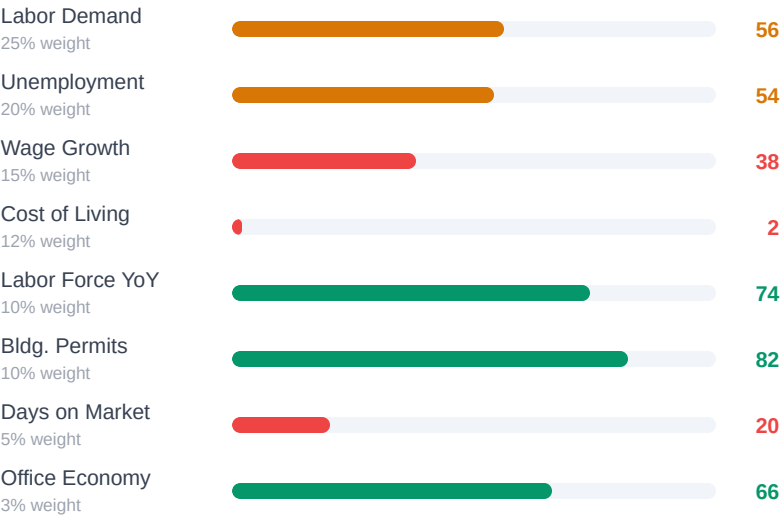
New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

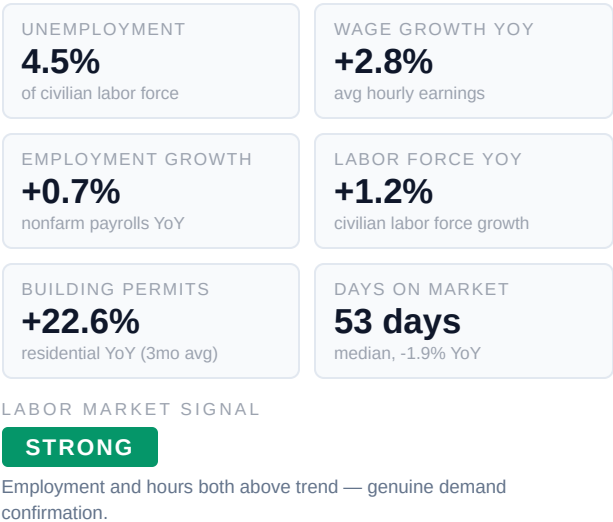
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.3th percentile
Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low cost of living affordability, ranked at the 2nd percentile, and its above-average labor force growth rate of 1.23% YoY. The combination of a high cost of living and moderate labor demand signals a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is 0.68% YoY, with weekly hours deviating 0.000% from its own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.25, which ranks at the 56th percentile. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs. However, the low labor demand score suggests that the job market is not extremely tight.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.50%, ranking at the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the moderate unemployment rate also implies that local consumer demand may not be extremely strong.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this metro area is 2.82%, ranking at the 38th percentile, indicating below-average wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other metros. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, but at a moderate rate.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is relatively expensive, with a PSF of \$522/sqft and an earnings ratio of 12.88, ranking at the 2nd percentile. This means that the city is one of the least affordable in the country, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 2.8% YoY increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of 1.23% YoY, ranking at the 74th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is increasing, with a growing pool of potential workers. However, the high cost of living may offset some of this advantage.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area has increased by 22.60% YoY, ranking at the 82nd percentile, indicating an expanding housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, as more housing units become available. However, the current cost of living remains a significant challenge.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 53 days, with a YoY decrease of 1.9%, ranking at the 20th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced housing market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The competitive market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in this metro area is 3.08, ranking at the 66th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and an expanding housing supply, but its high cost of living and moderate labor demand present significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the affordability of talent, as the high cost of living may require wage premiums to attract and retain workers.

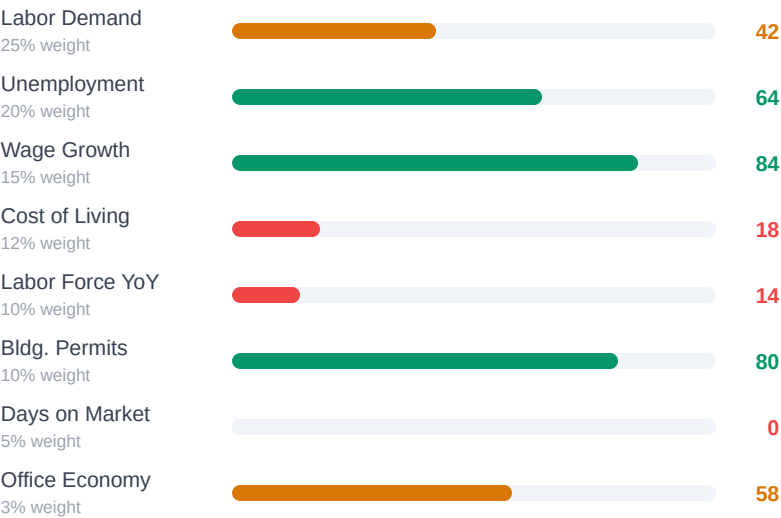
San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.2th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 6.15% year-over-year and its extremely low days on market for homes, currently at 39 days with a -13.3% year-over-year change. These metrics suggest a highly competitive job market and a challenging housing market for relocating workers.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 0.60% year-over-year, combined with a -0.223% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 4.92. This combination signals a modest expansion in job numbers but with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some level of genuine demand but not at an accelerated pace. The labor market is not experiencing significant contraction or survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.20%, ranking it at the 64th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the scarcity of available workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 6.15%, placing it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should anticipate higher compensation costs, but the local workforce will have increased disposable income, potentially benefiting consumer-facing industries.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 18th percentile, with a PSF (price per square foot) of \$629 and average hourly earnings of \$50.11, resulting in a PSF to earnings ratio of 12.55. The PSF has decreased by 4.8% year-over-year, which is a key factor in its relatively low affordability score. This means the city is expensive relative to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area has contracted by -1.59% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should be aware that finding and recruiting new employees may become increasingly difficult due to this declining labor force.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has increased by 19.88% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This increase suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the city is taking steps to address its housing needs, which could lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for relocating workers in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in this metro area currently sit on the market for a median of 39 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -13.3%. This extremely fast pace of home sales indicates a highly competitive housing market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The rapid sales pace suggests that the housing market is very hot, potentially pricing out some buyers.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a professional and office worker share that ranks it at the 58th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, it may not be as ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant. The city's economy is well-suited for knowledge-based businesses, offering a significant advantage in terms of accessing specialized talent.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and productive workforce, with strong wage growth indicating a robust local economy. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely high cost of living and the highly competitive housing market, which can make it difficult to attract and retain talent without significant wage premiums.

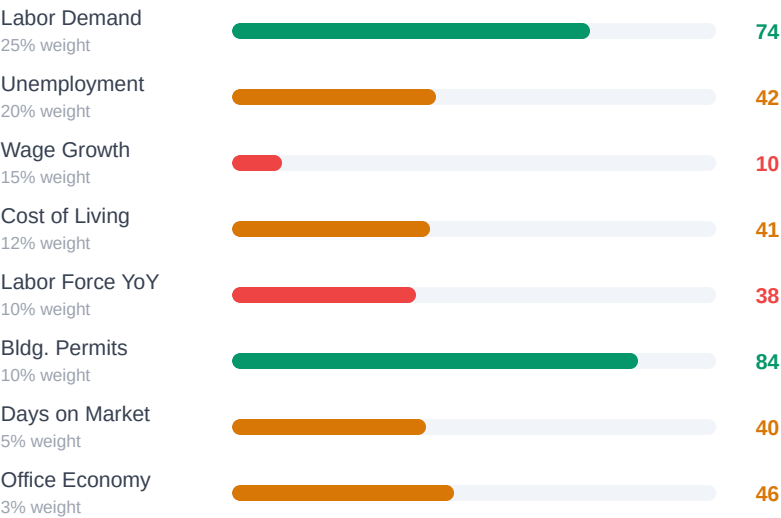
Birmingham

Birmingham

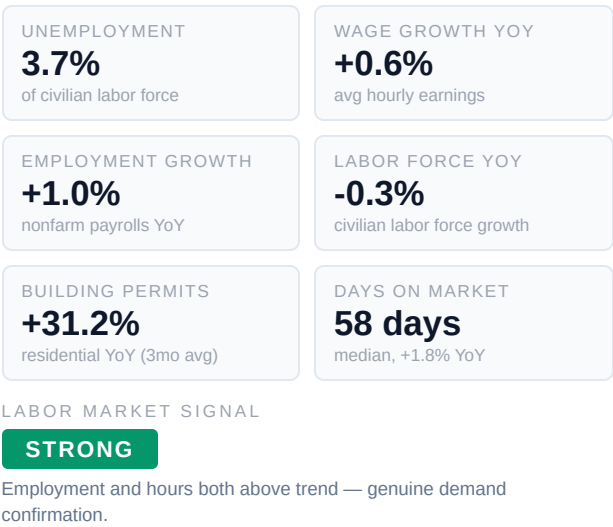
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.9th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 48.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and top-tier building permit growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.82, driven by a +0.97% employment growth rate and +0.164% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the +31.24% year-over-year change in building permits highlights a significant expansion in housing supply.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.97% and weekly hours deviation of +0.164% from its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.82 reinforces this interpretation, ranking the city in the 74th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham stands at 3.70%, ranking it in the 42nd percentile, which indicates a near-median level of unemployment. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also implies that there may be some upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.59%, Birmingham ranks in the 10th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that workers have weaker bargaining power and potentially less purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a more stable labor cost environment, but it may also limit the attractiveness of the city to workers seeking better compensation.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$160/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.48/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.93, ranks it in the 41st percentile. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The -1.2% year-over-year decrease in PSF relative to wages is a positive sign for affordability. This cost environment means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but the city does not stand out as a particularly affordable option either.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is shrinking at a rate of -0.28% year-over-year, ranking the city in the 38th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply indicates a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses

looking to expand or establish operations in Birmingham may face challenges in finding the necessary talent due to this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The +31.24% year-over-year increase in residential building permits in Birmingham signals a significant expansion in housing supply, ranking the city in the 84th percentile. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is expected to increase, which should improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Birmingham is 58 days, with a +1.8% year-over-year increase, ranking the city in the 40th percentile. This indicates a near-median pace of home sales, suggesting that the market is neither extremely competitive nor particularly slow. For workers relocating to Birmingham, this means that they may face a moderately competitive housing market, but it is not excessively challenging to find a home.

Office Economy

Birmingham's share of professional and office workers is 2.42, ranking it in the 46th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors, but it may not be as competitive as cities with a more specialized or larger professional workforce.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a unique combination of above-average labor demand and significant housing supply expansion, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to capitalize on a growing workforce and improving affordability. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the stagnant wage growth, which may limit the city's appeal to workers and necessitate careful consideration of compensation packages to attract and retain talent.

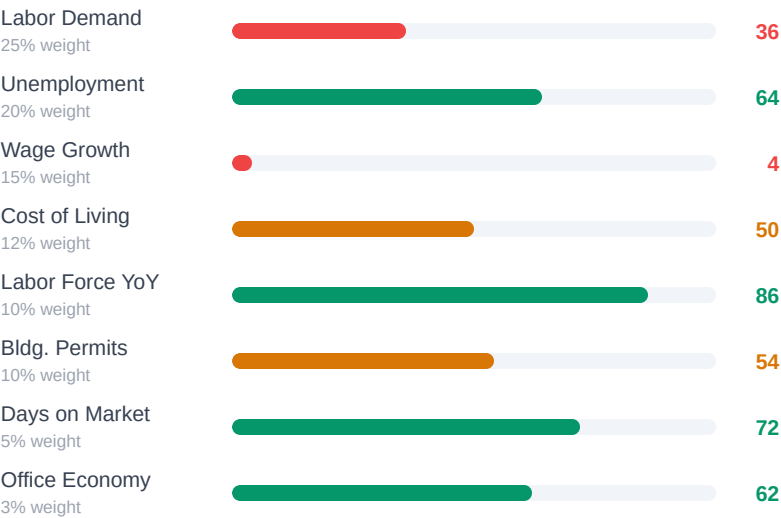
Cleveland

Cleveland

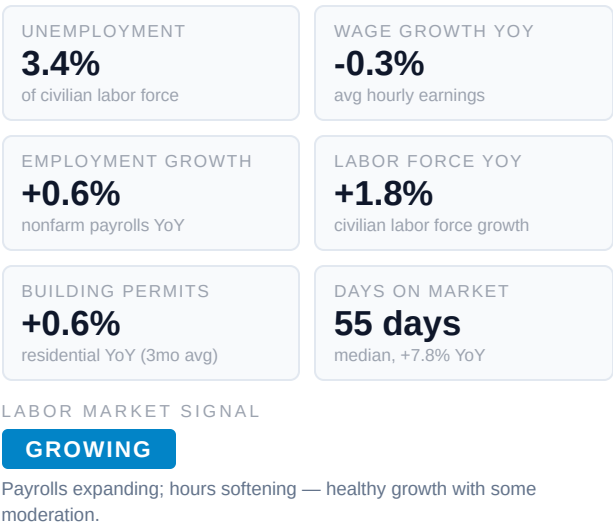
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.9th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.66 ranking it in the 36th percentile, and its stagnant wage growth, with a year-over-year change of -0.32% ranking it in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is 0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.437% from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative hours deviation suggests that businesses may be absorbing the workload with existing staff rather than hiring new employees.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking it in the 64th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that there may be upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

Cleveland's year-over-year wage growth is -0.32%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing significantly, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. This could impact the overall attractiveness of the city to businesses and workers alike.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living is near the median, with a percentile rank of 50th, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$143/sqft to \$33.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.23. The city's cost of living is not particularly advantageous or disadvantageous, but the 13.5% year-over-year increase in PSF suggests that affordability may be decreasing. This could impact the city's ability to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of 1.80% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This expanding labor force supply suggests that businesses may have an easier time finding qualified workers, and the city may be more attractive to businesses looking to hire.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cleveland is increasing by 0.56% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate growth in housing supply suggests that the city's affordability and workforce accommodation may improve in the future, but the slow pace of growth may not keep up with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.8%, ranking it in the 72nd percentile. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, and workers relocating to the city may find it more accessible. However, the relatively slow pace of sales may also indicate a less competitive market.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional and office worker share is 3.04, ranking it in the 62nd percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it suitable for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, it may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a relatively tight labor market and a growing labor force, but its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor demand, which may impact businesses' ability to expand or relocate.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.4th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		78
25% weight		
Unemployment		14
20% weight		
Wage Growth		26
15% weight		
Cost of Living		67
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		66
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		14
10% weight		
Days on Market		48
5% weight		
Office Economy		90
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -22.3% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 54 days median, +1.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 6.24 ranking it in the 78th percentile, and its relatively low unemployment rate of 4.70%, which ranks it in the 14th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a strong job market but also significant competition for labor.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 1.27% year-over-year, combined with a 0.162% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is experiencing real growth rather than just a redistribution of existing work. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.70%, ranking it in the 14th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this market, the practical implication is that it may face some competition for talent, but there are still available workers to be found. However, the relatively low unemployment rate suggests that wages may be under upward pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 1.95%, which ranks it in the 26th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but at a pace that is somewhat slower than in many other cities. For workers, this means that their purchasing power is increasing, but not as quickly as it might be in cities with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a cost of living score that ranks it in the 67th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$201/sqft to \$37.13/hr, or 5.41. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage for businesses that do not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.9% year-over-year relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of 0.73% year-over-year, which ranks it in the 66th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the area. An expanding

labor force can help to mitigate some of the competitive pressure for talent that comes with a low unemployment rate.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has fallen by 22.31% year-over-year, ranking it in the 14th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. This is a potential risk for businesses that rely on being able to attract talent from elsewhere.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.9%, ranking it in the 48th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced market that is neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is accessible but not overly favorable to buyers, which could impact their decision to move.

Office Economy

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking it in the 90th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suited for businesses in more industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong job market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult to attract talent from elsewhere.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.3th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		18
Unemployment 20% weight		34
Wage Growth 15% weight		44
Cost of Living 12% weight		16
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		98
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		92
Days on Market 5% weight		98
Office Economy 3% weight		52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.4% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +2.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +67.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 46 days median, +17.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth of +2.87% YoY and its high building permits growth of +67.46% YoY, indicating a expanding workforce and housing supply. However, its labor demand composite score of 3.82 ranks in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, suggesting a mismatch between job growth and hours worked.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +0.39% YoY, while weekly hours are -1.026% below trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that despite some job growth, the overall labor market is not as strong as it could be, with hours worked below the 12-month baseline. This may indicate a degree of survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking in the below-average tier at the 34th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. While this is not an extremely tight market, it still presents some challenges for businesses trying to hire, as they may face competition for available workers. However, it is not as severe as in cities with even lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +3.21%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, this pace of wage growth is not exceptionally high, which may limit the attractiveness of the city to businesses seeking to minimize labor costs.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living score ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, with a PSF of \$474/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$45.50/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.42. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.0% YoY is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of +2.87% YoY, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce. This suggests that the city has a strong supply of potential workers, which can support business growth and hiring capacity. This is a significant advantage for businesses looking to expand their operations in the area.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of +67.46% YoY, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the city is likely to see improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for workers in the future. This is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is currently 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of +17.9%, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This indicates a slowing market, which may make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city to find housing. However, the absolute level of days on market is still relatively low, suggesting that the market remains competitive.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 2.78, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be as attractive for industries with more specialized or industrial workforce requirements. The city's office economy is neither exceptionally strong nor weak, making it a viable option for a range of businesses.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a rapidly expanding workforce and housing supply, but also presents challenges due to its relatively high cost of living and moderate labor market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential difficulty in attracting talent without offering wage premiums, due to the city's expensive cost of living. However, the city's strong labor force growth and expanding housing supply make it an attractive option for businesses looking to grow and expand their operations.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.3th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)

Labor Demand		34
25% weight		
Unemployment		24
20% weight		
Wage Growth		68
15% weight		
Cost of Living		80
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		44
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		38
10% weight		
Days on Market		80
5% weight		
Office Economy		2
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.2% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -6.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 52 days median, +6.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.39, and its above-average wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.07%. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends in wage growth but challenges in labor demand.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is 0.15% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.117% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The below-average labor demand composite score of 4.39 further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.20%, which is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This suggests a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. Companies looking to staff up in this city may face challenges in finding available talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is 5.07% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast pace of wage growth, which can lead to rising labor costs for employers but also increases worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living score that ranks at the 80th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$172/sqft to \$33.58/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.12. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The high affordability score means that Oklahoma City has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a decent standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is growing at a rate of -0.04% year-over-year, which is near the median. This indicates a slightly contracting labor pool, presenting a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract talent from outside the city or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Oklahoma City has decreased by 6.14% year-over-year. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for the workforce to find accommodation. This trend may negatively impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.1%. This ranks at the 80th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market means that they have more time to find a home, making the city more accessible for relocation.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share is ranked at the 2nd percentile, with a composite score of 0.36. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a mixed economic environment with above-average wage growth but below-average labor demand. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability challenges and impact talent attraction and retention. Despite this, the city's relative affordability and slower housing market may still make it an attractive option for certain types of businesses.

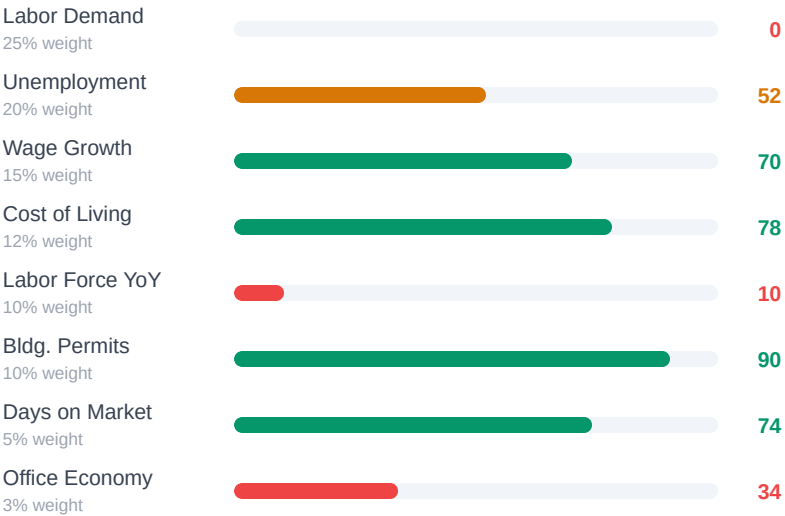
Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

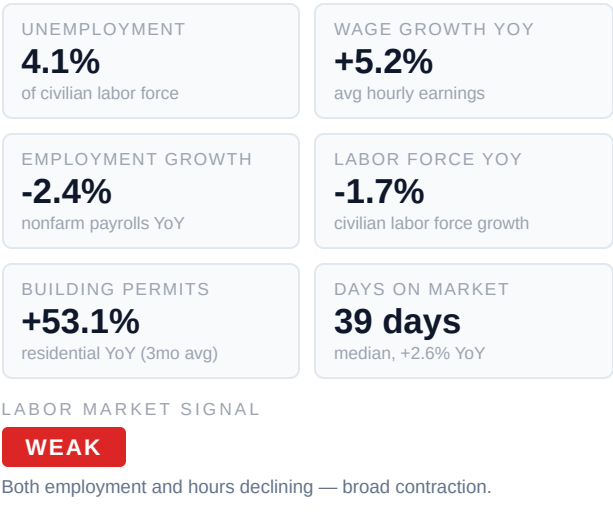
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.9th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its strong wage growth, at 5.20% year-over-year. The combination of a 4.10% unemployment rate and 5.20% wage growth suggests a complex labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.870% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.10%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, but it is not excessively loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate implies that finding talent may be manageable, but it may not be as easy as in cities with higher unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.20%, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power. This could be beneficial for businesses that rely on a highly skilled and motivated workforce.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score ranking it above average at the 78th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$305/sqft to \$45.00/hr, or 6.78. The fact that PSF is falling -1.9% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming more affordable relative to wages. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live here without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -1.70% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity may be constrained, making it more challenging for businesses to find and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by 53.15% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This rapid expansion in housing supply suggests that the city's affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%. This relatively fast market, ranking above average at the 74th percentile, implies that workers relocating to this city may face a competitive housing market, but it is still accessible.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is below average, ranking at the 34th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep as in other metros, making it less suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, but its weak labor demand and declining labor force supply pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the city's limited hiring capacity, which may hinder a business's ability to find and retain talent in the long run.

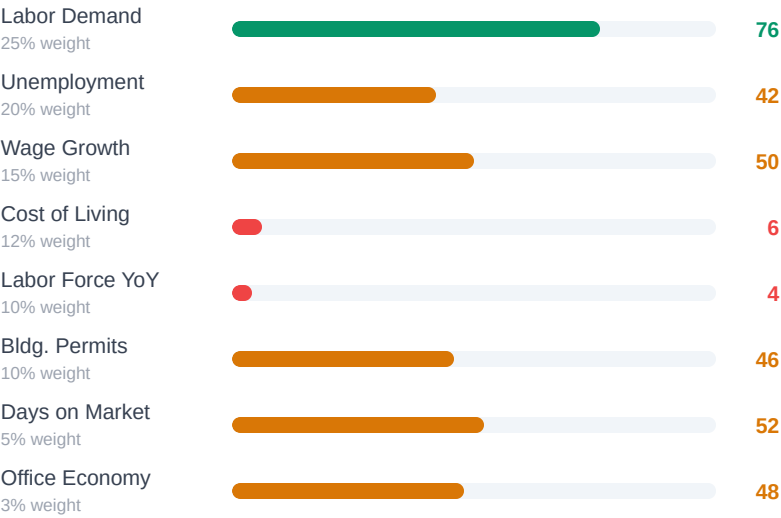
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

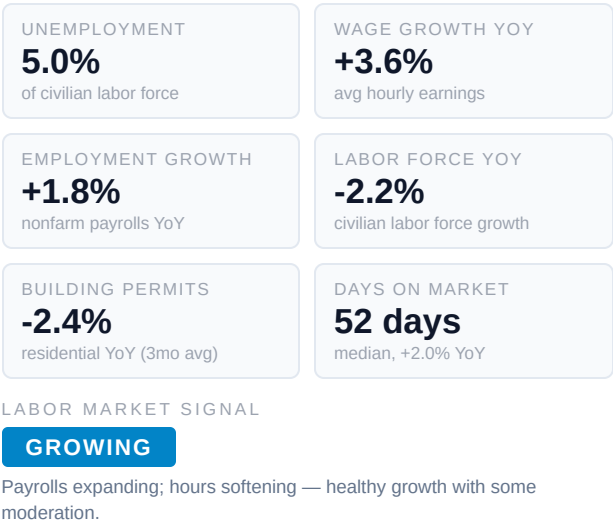
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.7th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 5.96 ranking it in the 76th percentile, and its cost of living, which is in the bottom tier with a 6th percentile rank due to a high PSF to wages ratio of \$659/sqft to \$41.35/hr. The labor demand and cost of living metrics provide a mixed picture of the city's economic health.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 1.83% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.906% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.96, ranking in the 76th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 5.00%, ranking in the 42nd percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This means the market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 3.57%, ranking in the 50th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means labor costs for employers are rising at a moderate pace, while worker purchasing power is increasing. The wage growth rate is neither exceptionally high nor stagnant, suggesting a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has a cost of living percentile rank of 6, indicating it is one of the more expensive cities relative to peers. The PSF to wages ratio of \$659/sqft to \$41.35/hr is high, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The city's affordability is a significant concern, with the cost of living being a major drawback.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is contracting at a rate of -2.24% year-over-year, ranking in the 4th percentile. This means the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers due to the declining labor force.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is decreasing at a rate of -2.43% year-over-year, ranking in the 46th percentile. This indicates that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%. This suggests a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 2.46, ranking in the 48th percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may not be as well-suited for industries requiring a large industrial or logistics workforce.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a mixed bag, with a strong labor demand and moderate wage growth, but also a high cost of living and shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's affordability, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

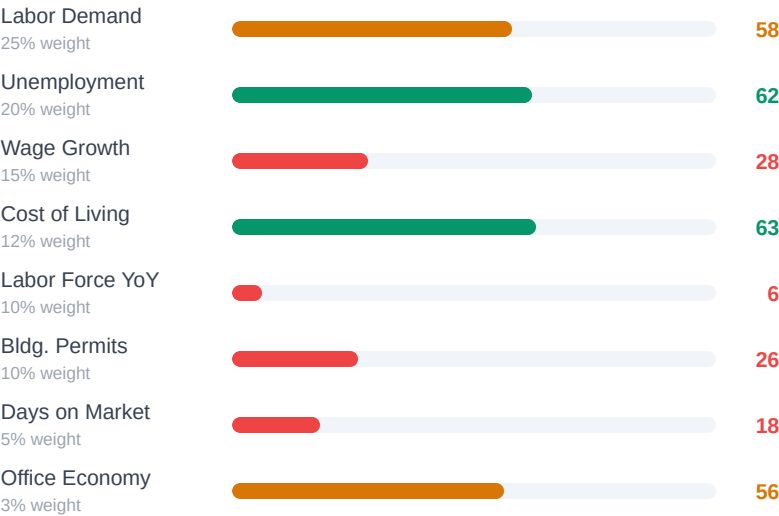
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

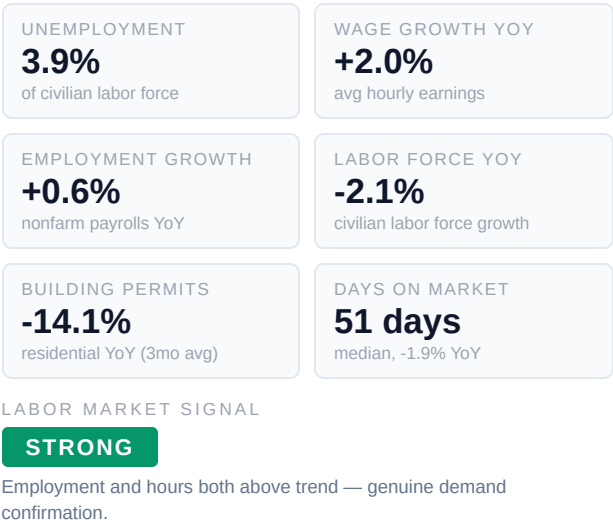
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.5th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 5.29, which is near the median at the 58th percentile, and its wage growth rate of +2.01%, which is below average at the 28th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a mixed economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +0.60% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.147% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing, indicating a growing need for labor. The labor demand composite score of 5.29 reinforces this signal.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.90%, which ranks at the 62nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire, and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. Businesses trying to hire in this market may face challenges in finding available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +2.01%, which is below average at the 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not strongly. This may impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score that ranks at the 63rd percentile, with a PSF of \$284/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.34/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.71. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling -3.1% year-over-year further supports this affordability. This makes the city more attractive for talent attraction without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is contracting at a rate of -2.15% year-over-year, which ranks at the 6th percentile. This means that the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may face challenges in finding workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is decreasing by -14.11% year-over-year, which ranks at the 26th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could impact the city's ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 51 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.9%, ranking at the 18th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The market is competitive, and workers may face pressure to act quickly when finding a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 2.86, ranking at the 56th percentile. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, it may not be as well-suited for industries that require a large number of industrial or logistics workers.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers a mixed economic environment, with both opportunities and challenges for businesses. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may limit the city's ability to support growing businesses. Despite this, the city's relatively affordable cost of living and moderate wage growth make it an attractive location for businesses looking to establish or expand operations.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C+

POOR

43.9th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		16
25% weight		
Unemployment		68
20% weight		
Wage Growth		24
15% weight		
Cost of Living		22
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		80
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		64
10% weight		
Days on Market		96
5% weight		
Office Economy		28
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.8%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +1.6%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.4%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +1.7%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) +9.9%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +16.7% YoY 35 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its relatively high unemployment rate, which is still above average at 68th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 3.80 and unemployment rate of 3.80% are key metrics that shape the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.36% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.511% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may not face intense competition for labor, but it also implies a slower pace of economic activity.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.56%, which is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may lead to a relatively stable labor cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score that ranks at the 22nd percentile, with a PSF of \$227/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.18/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.27. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF is increasing by 1.8% year-over-year, which may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +1.66% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking at the 80th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +9.94% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 64th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for its workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is currently 35 days, with a year-over-year increase of +16.7%, ranking at the 96th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also suggest a normalization of the housing market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office or professional skills, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries with less specialized labor requirements.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a relatively stable labor cost environment and an expanding labor force supply, but its low labor demand and relatively high cost of living may pose challenges for talent attraction and retention. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand, which may indicate a slower pace of economic activity and limited opportunities for growth.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

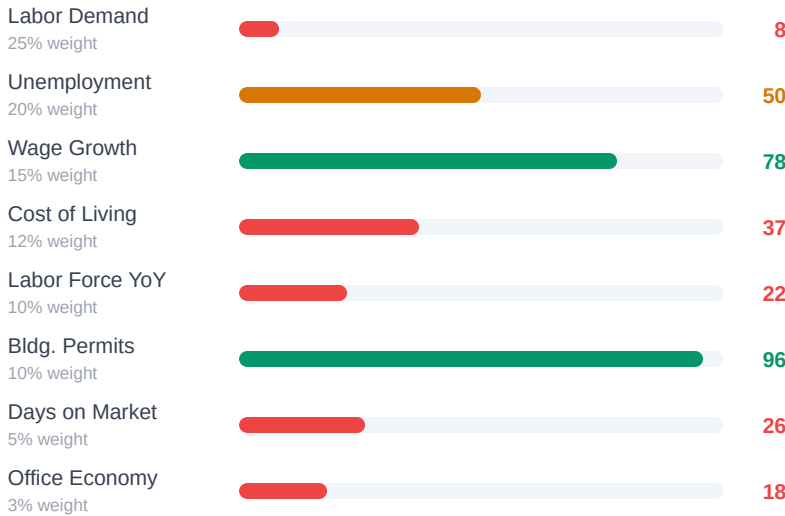
C+

POOR

41.7th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.9%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.1%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+106.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 3.01 ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.91% in hourly earnings. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.55% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.523%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked, which may lead to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.00%, ranking it near the median at the 50th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the availability of labor.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 5.91%, ranking it above average at the 78th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which will lead to rising labor costs for employers but also increase worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is below average, with a percentile rank of 37th, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$224/sqft to \$35.28/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.35. However, the PSF is increasing by 2.8% year-over-year, which may erode affordability over time. This relatively low cost of living could be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in this metro area is shrinking, with a year-over-year growth rate of -1.05%, ranking it below average at the 22nd percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in this metro area has increased by 106.92% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 39 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing, potentially affecting a business's ability to attract and retain talent.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in this metro area is relatively low, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests a less deep talent pool for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, making it less suited for tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, but potentially more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex economic environment with strong wage growth but low labor demand and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering this location is the challenge of finding and recruiting talent due to the contracting labor force supply, which may outweigh the benefits of relatively low costs and expanding housing supply.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

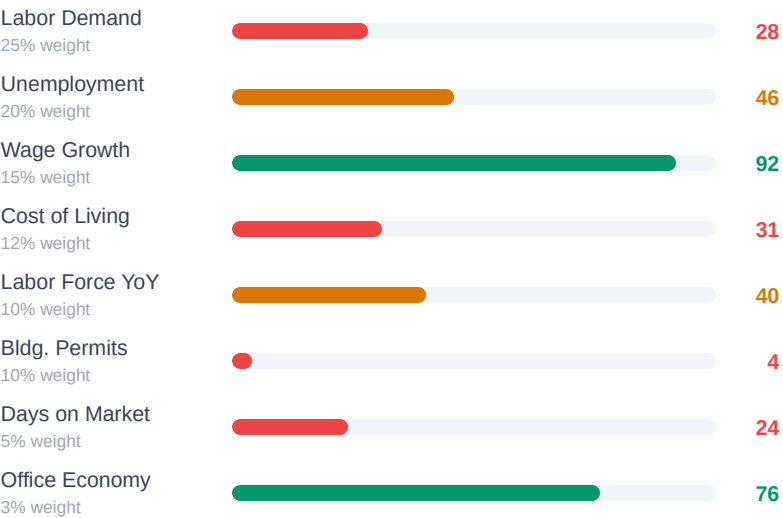
C+

POOR

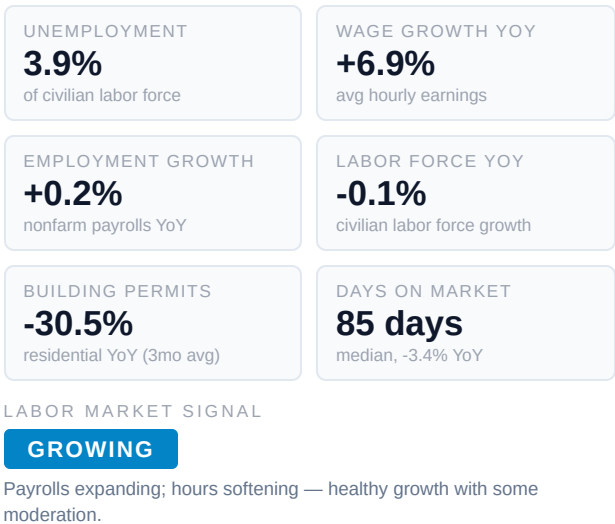
41.6th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.93%, and its struggling labor demand, with a composite score of 4.29 ranking below average at the 28th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.18% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.262% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor demand contraction, as the small employment growth is accompanied by a decrease in hours worked, indicating a lack of genuine demand expansion. This contraction may lead to a surplus of workers, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also potentially indicating a weaker local economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it neither extremely tight nor extremely loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that finding qualified workers may be relatively manageable, but wage pressure may not be as high as in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 6.93%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand. Businesses operating in this city should be prepared for higher labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local workforce.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score ranking below average at the 31st percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$356/sqft to \$34.40/hr, or 10.35. Although the PSF is decreasing by 0.8% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging, as the high cost of living could offset the benefits of the city's strong wage growth.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This slight contraction in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses should be aware of this trend and plan accordingly, potentially considering strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -30.46%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This sharp decline in permits signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This trend poses a risk to workforce accommodation and may make it more difficult for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.4%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decreasing trend in days on market may signal a normalization of the housing market, potentially leading to a more balanced and accessible environment for homebuyers in the future.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy score ranking above average at the 76th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which can leverage the available specialized workforce. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented profiles.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the city's struggling labor demand, decreasing labor force supply, and tightening housing market pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business operations.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

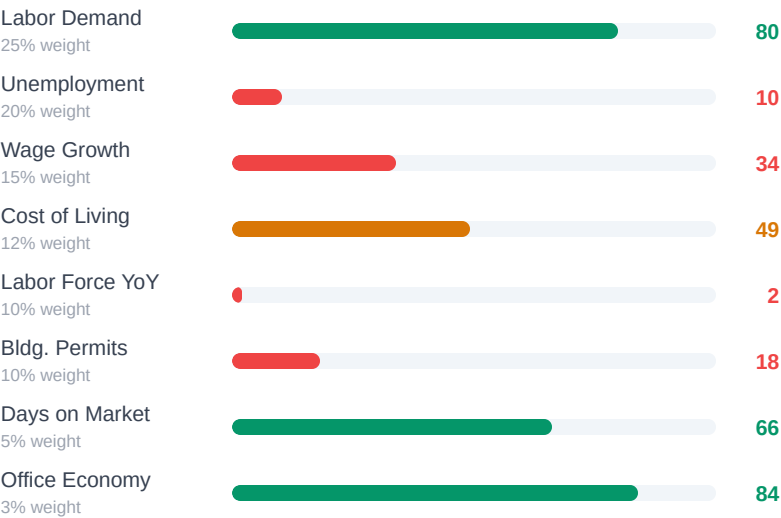
C+

POOR

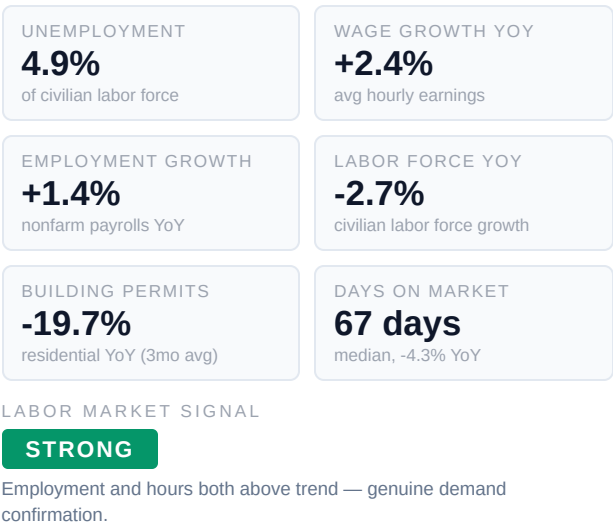
40.8th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 80th percentile ranking, and its low unemployment rate, which is in the 10th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 6.27, driven by a +1.37% employment growth rate and +0.048% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.37% and weekly hours deviation of +0.048% indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The top-tier ranking of 80th percentile for labor demand composite score reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.90% is relatively low, ranking in the 10th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate implies that workers have more bargaining power, making it essential for employers to offer competitive compensation packages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.39% is below average, ranking in the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers' purchasing power is increasing, albeit slowly. The relatively slow wage growth may help keep labor costs in check, but it may also limit workers' ability to afford rising living costs.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.14, based on \$267/sqft (which is decreasing by 1.5% YoY) and \$37.40/hr, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler ranks in the 49th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF value is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.70% year-over-year, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity may be constrained, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain workers. The shrinking labor pool is a significant structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's economic growth potential.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -19.67%, ranking in the 18th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The sharp decrease in permits may lead to increased housing costs and reduced affordability.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 67 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.3%, ranking in the 66th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The fast-paced market may require workers to act rapidly when finding a home, potentially leading to a competitive and stressful relocation experience.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 3.72, ranking in the 84th percentile, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's strong office economy makes it an attractive location for businesses requiring specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a tight labor market with low unemployment, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the shrinking labor pool, which may limit hiring capacity and constrain economic growth. This factor should be carefully weighed in any business location decision.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

C+

POOR

40.6th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		46
Unemployment 20% weight		28
Wage Growth 15% weight		40
Cost of Living 12% weight		0
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		82
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		34
Days on Market 5% weight		78
Office Economy 3% weight		68

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.3% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +1.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -8.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 38 days median, +2.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.17, ranking it at the 0th percentile for affordability. The labor demand composite score of 5.11, near the median at the 46th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.025% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as the job market is growing, albeit slowly. The near-median labor demand composite score of 5.11, at the 46th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking it at the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +3.00%, ranking it near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the area are experiencing a modest increase in purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 0th percentile, making it one of the most expensive cities relative to peers, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.17 (\$367/sqft vs \$36.07/hr). This high cost of living means that the city is at a disadvantage in terms of talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, ranking it at the 82nd percentile. This expansion of the labor force supply implies that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has decreased by -8.13% year-over-year, ranking it at the 34th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is currently 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.7%, ranking it at the 78th percentile. This relatively slow market means that workers relocating to the city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy score that ranks it at the 68th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Providence-Warwick offers businesses a growing labor force and a deep professional talent pool, but its high cost of living and tightening housing supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk for decision-makers is the potential for decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation, which could impact the city's attractiveness to businesses and workers alike.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

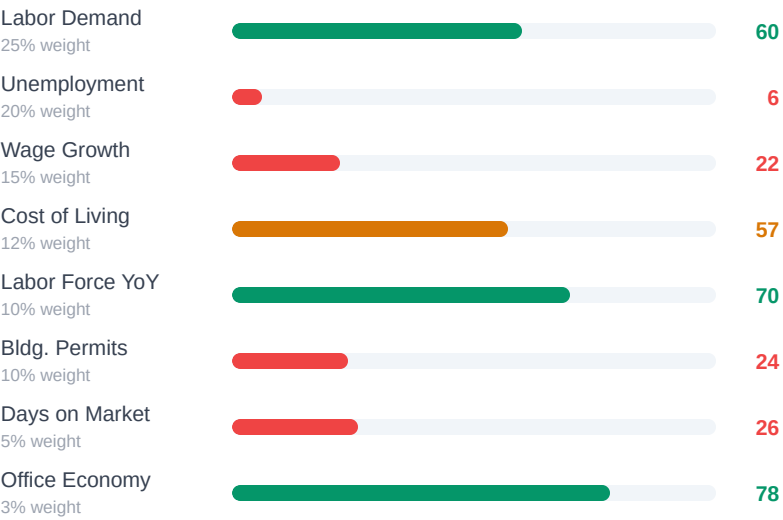
C+

POOR

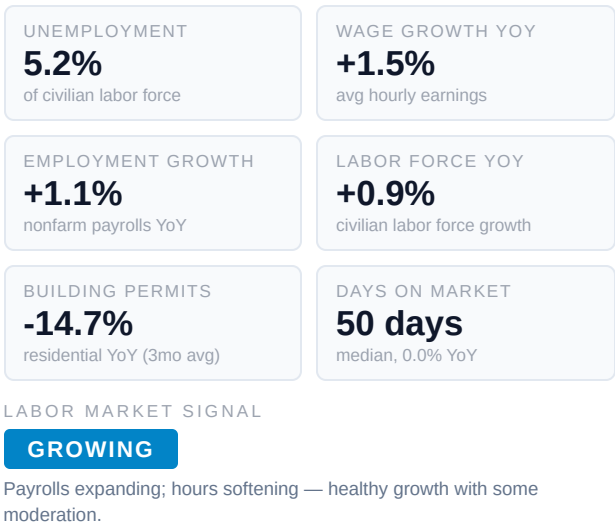
39.4th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 60th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which ranks in the 6th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both positive and negative signals.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.14% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.342%. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs, albeit with slightly fewer hours worked than expected. This suggests that the labor market is growing, but not at an explosive pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 5.20%, ranking it in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also potentially weakening local consumer demand. As a result, businesses may face less wage pressure when hiring, but may also need to consider the potential impact on local sales.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.52%, ranking it in the 22nd percentile, indicating relatively slow wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power may also be limited. As a result, businesses may enjoy a relatively flat cost environment, but workers may have limited bargaining power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$171/sqft to \$36.01/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 2.3% in PSF, this city ranks in the 57th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF is a key driver of this affordability, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is growing at a rate of 0.88% year-over-year, ranking it in the 70th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive signal for businesses looking to hire. As a result, the city's hiring capacity is likely to increase, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to grow.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -14.66%, ranking it in the 24th percentile, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This suggests that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, potentially making it more difficult for workers to relocate. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on workforce accommodation and future affordability.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with no year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively stable housing market, which may be neither highly competitive nor highly accessible for relocating workers. As a result, businesses may not need to worry about extreme competition for housing, but may still need to consider the potential impact on worker relocation.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share ranking in the 78th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, this also means that the city may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which may require a different type of workforce.

In conclusion, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands offers businesses a relatively affordable location with a growing labor force and a deep professional talent pool. However, the city's high unemployment rate and tightening housing supply are significant risks that decision-makers should factor in, as they may impact local consumer demand and future affordability.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

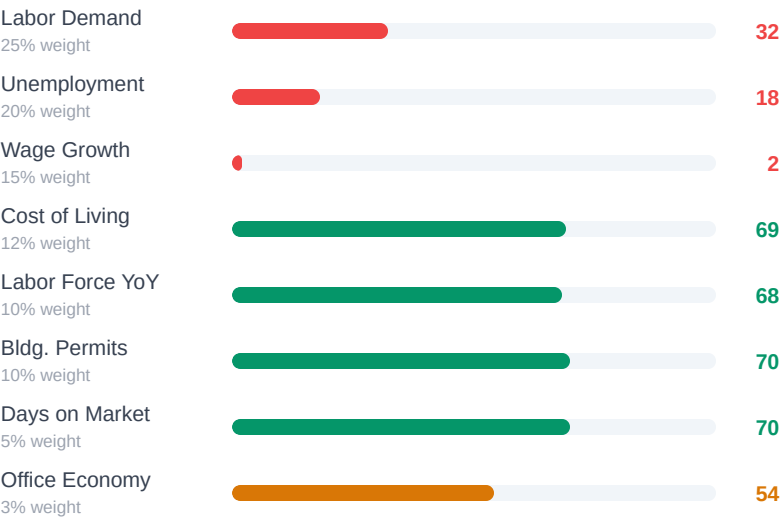
C+

POOR

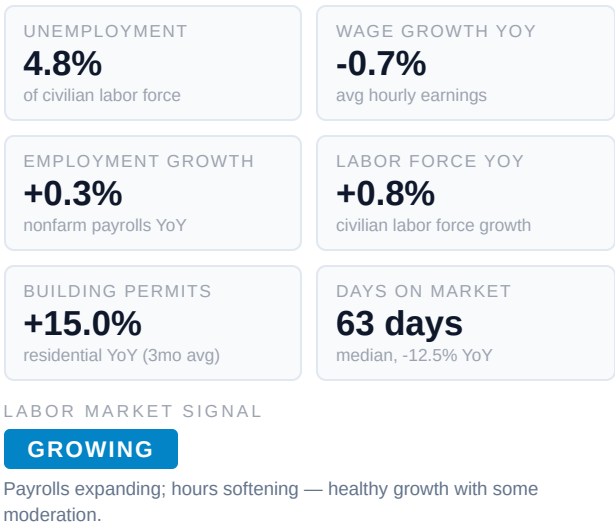
39.1th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.80% and its stagnant wage growth of -0.68% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with weak wage pressure. These metrics suggest that while businesses may face challenges in hiring, they may also benefit from a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is 0.33% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation is -0.372% below its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.39, which ranks below average at the 32nd percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The below-average labor demand suggests that businesses may not face intense competition for workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, ranking it at the 18th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages or benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Jacksonville is -0.68%, ranking it at the 2nd percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but may also not benefit from a highly motivated workforce.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score ranking it at the 69th percentile, with a PSF of \$216/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.43, resulting in a ratio of 5.93. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The affordability of Jacksonville means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of 0.78% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 68th percentile. This expanding labor force supply implies that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent. As a result, businesses may face less competition for workers and have more opportunities to attract top talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Jacksonville is increasing by 15.03% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 70th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is becoming more accommodating to a growing workforce, which may lead to improved affordability and reduced pressure on the housing market. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain workers who can afford to live in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 63 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 12.5%, ranking it above average at the 70th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, making it accessible for workers relocating to the city. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract talent from other areas, as workers can quickly find and purchase or rent homes.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share ranks at the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median depth of talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized knowledge workers, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

The city of Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable and accessible environment, with a growing labor force and expanding housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tight labor market and stagnant wage growth, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and create challenges for hiring and retention. As a result, businesses should carefully consider their hiring strategies and compensation packages to attract and retain top talent in this market.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

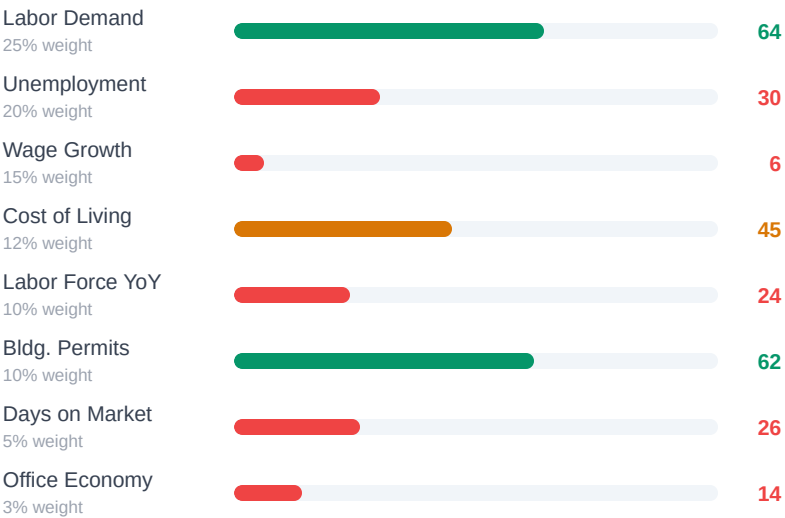
C+

POOR

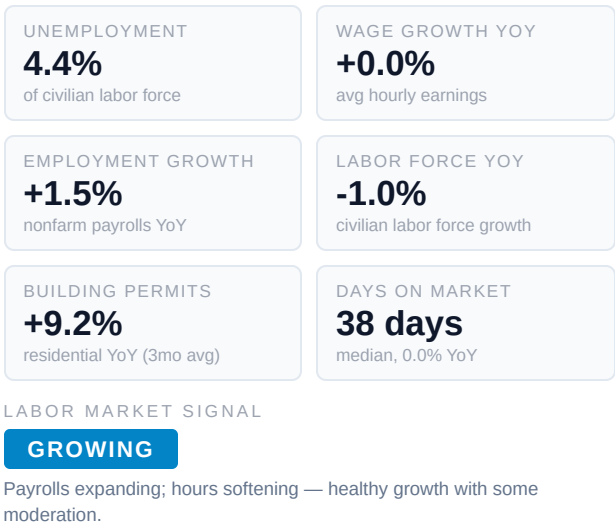
38.6th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 38.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is above average, and its stagnant wage growth, ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 5.63, driven by a 1.46% employment growth rate and -0.718% weekly hours deviation, signals a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.46% and weekly hours deviation of -0.718% indicate a labor market with genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth. This combination suggests that the city is adding jobs at a moderate pace, with workers' hours not being overly stretched. The labor demand composite score of 5.63 ranks in the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile, which means the market has some slack but is not extremely loose. This implies that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent, and businesses may face moderate wage pressure. The relatively low unemployment rate suggests that the local consumer demand is not extremely weak.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 0.01% is stagnant, ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power. The stagnant wage growth may limit the purchasing power of workers, potentially affecting local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$208/sqft and earnings of \$39.46/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.27, ranks near the median at 45th percentile. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.9% YoY is a positive sign for affordability. This cost of living profile may not provide a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.97% year-over-year, ranking in the 24th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may face challenges in finding and

recruiting talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is 9.15%, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 38 days, with a 0% year-over-year change. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 26th percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, as homes are selling quickly. However, the stable days on market suggests a balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor accessible.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 1.26, ranking in the bottom tier at 14th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers a business a labor market with genuine demand expansion and a relatively low unemployment rate, but it also comes with the risk of a stagnant wage growth environment and a contracting labor force supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the potential challenge in finding and recruiting talent due to the shrinking labor pool, which may limit the city's attractiveness for businesses with high labor demands.

Fresno

Fresno

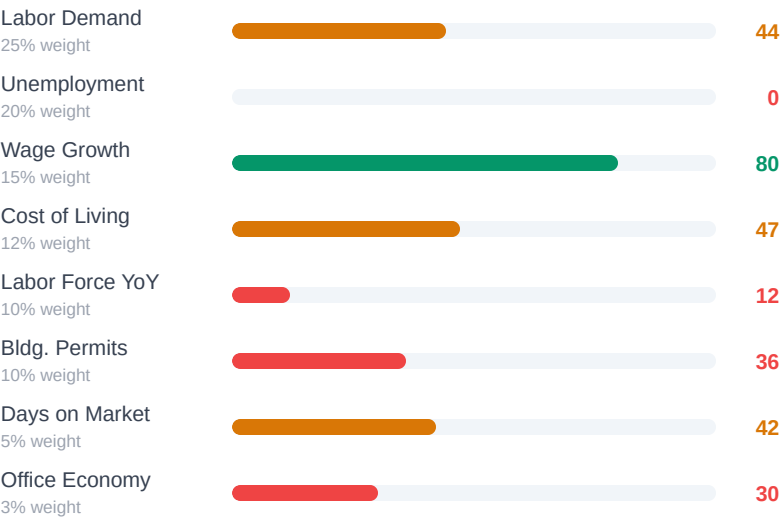
C

VERY POOR

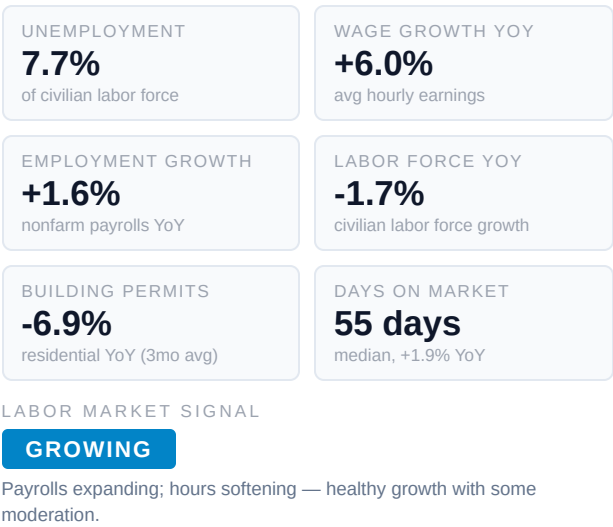
36.4th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.04. The city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 5.96% and its low unemployment rate of 7.70%, which indicates a tight labor market. These metrics suggest that Fresno has a strong demand for labor, but also faces challenges in terms of labor supply and affordability.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 1.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -2.051% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs, but hours worked are slightly below trend. This suggests that the labor market is growing, but not at a rapid pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.70%, which is the lowest percentile rank, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also implies that workers have more bargaining power, which can drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Fresno is 5.96%, which is in the top tier, ranking 80th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising rapidly, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. This can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand, but may be a challenge for those with tight profit margins.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living percentile rank of 47th, with a PSF of \$263/sqft and an hourly earnings ratio of \$33.62/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.82. This indicates that the city is near median in terms of affordability, neither extremely expensive nor very affordable. This means that businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to low costs, but also do not need to offer large wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is contracting at a rate of -1.69% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 12th percentile. This implies that the labor pool is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Fresno is -6.89%, which is below average, ranking 36th percentile. This indicates that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation. This may be a challenge for businesses that rely on a mobile workforce or need to attract talent from other areas.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.9%. This indicates a near median market pace, neither extremely fast nor slow. For workers relocating to this city, the market is relatively accessible, but not extremely competitive, which can be beneficial for businesses that need to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

Fresno has an office economy percentile rank of 30th, with a share of professional and office workers of 1.86. This indicates that the city has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

The city of Fresno offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a tight labor market, but also poses challenges in terms of labor supply and affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool, which can create a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion, and may require businesses to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C

VERY POOR

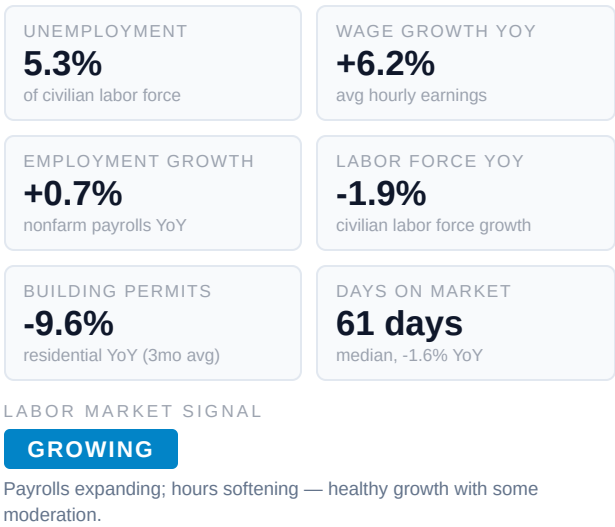
36.3th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and relatively low unemployment rate. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 6.17% year-over-year and its below-average labor demand composite score of 4.00, indicating a mixed economic environment. Specifically, the wage growth and labor demand metrics suggest a city with rising labor costs and a moderate level of job market activity.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.65% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.215% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score that signals a moderate level of job market activity. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing some genuine demand expansion, but at a slower pace than many of its peers. The below-average labor demand composite score of 24th percentile suggests that the city's job market is not as strong as others.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.30%, which is below average, ranking 32nd percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also suggests that wage pressure may be rising, as workers have more bargaining power in a tighter labor market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 6.17%, which is a top-tier rate, ranking 86th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising rapidly, which may be a challenge for businesses. On the other hand, strong wage growth also means that workers have more purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score that is near median, ranking 43rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$333/sqft to \$35.56/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.36. The fact that the price per square foot is falling -1.8% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming more affordable. This means that businesses can attract talent without having to offer significant wage premiums, as the city's affordability is a competitive advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, which is a bottom-tier rate, ranking 8th percentile. This implies that the workforce supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. The declining labor force growth rate suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is falling -9.60% year-over-year, which is a below-average rate, ranking 32nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 61 days, with a year-over-year decline of -1.6%. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the housing market is competitive, making it challenging for relocating workers to find homes. The below-average days on market percentile rank of 38th percentile implies that the city's housing market is relatively hot.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a very shallow professional talent pool, ranking 0th percentile, with only 0.22 (on a 0-5 scale) of jobs in professional and office sectors. This suggests that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, the city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a mixed economic environment, with strong wage growth and a relatively low unemployment rate, but also a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the declining labor force growth rate, which may create challenges in finding qualified workers and limit the city's potential for long-term business expansion.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

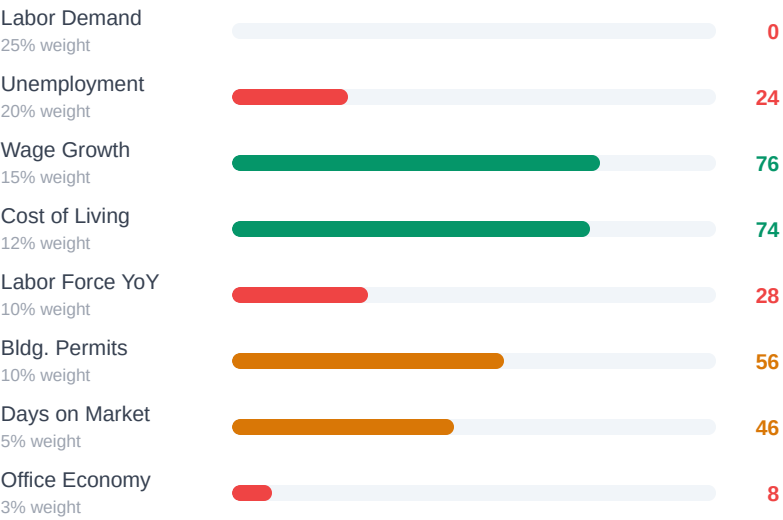
C

VERY POOR

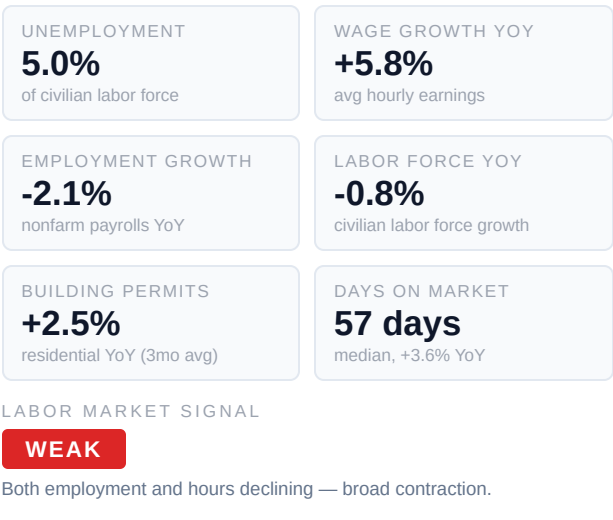
36.0th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.0th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and high wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.07% employment growth rate and a -0.245% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with a strong wage growth rate of 5.82%, suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -2.07% and weekly hours deviation of -0.245% from the city's own trend indicate a contraction in labor demand, signaling that the city is experiencing a period of job losses and reduced working hours. This combination suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion, instead pointing towards a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers may absorb the workload of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 1.50 falls into the bottom tier, at the 0th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.00% places the city below the average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This rate indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire in this city is that while there may be a pool of available workers, the overall labor market conditions are not highly favorable.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.82%, the city experiences above-average wage increases, ranking at the 76th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates good worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for increased labor expenses when considering this location.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro, with a PSF of \$306/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$42.08/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.27, is considered above average in terms of affordability, ranking at the 74th percentile. This means the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, especially since the PSF is falling by 2.2% YoY. This affordability could serve as a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area is contracting at a rate of -0.81% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This negative growth rate suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing.

Businesses should consider this constraint when planning for future workforce needs.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 2.48% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, which is near the median, ranking at the 56th percentile. This increase signals that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

Homes in the Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro area are currently sitting on the market for a median of 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.6%. This indicates a slightly slower market compared to the previous year. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is becoming more accessible, as homes are not selling as quickly as they were, providing more time for decision-making.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 0.68, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, and may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a complex mix of economic conditions, with high wage growth and relative affordability being notable advantages. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering this location is the weak labor demand and contracting labor force, which could significantly impact hiring capacity and business expansion plans.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

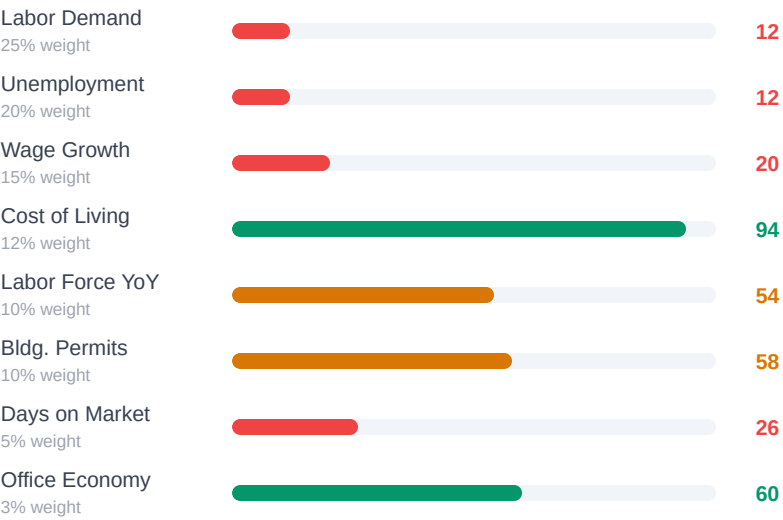
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VERY POOR

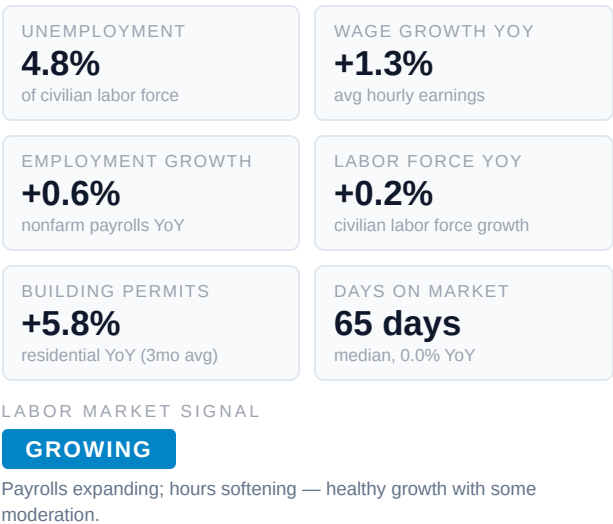
34.0th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34th out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of weak labor demand and affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 3.65, which combines a modest employment growth rate of +0.61% with a significant deviation of -2.35% in weekly hours from its own trend. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.61% is modest, while the weekly hours deviation of -2.35% indicates that hours are running below trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine expansion. This combination suggests that the labor market is not experiencing strong growth, and businesses may not face intense competition for workers. The labor demand composite score of 3.65, ranking in the 12th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% is relatively high, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating that the labor market has some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. With a relatively high unemployment rate, businesses may have a larger pool of potential employees to draw from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.33% is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating moderate wage pressure. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face strong upward pressure on wages, but may also not see significant increases in consumer spending.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living ratio of \$172/sqft to \$32.51/hr, with a PSF that is falling by -4.4% year-over-year, resulting in a top-tier percentile rank of 94th. This indicates that the city is highly affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF is a key driver of this affordability, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.23% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 54th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This moderate growth rate suggests that the labor pool is not shrinking, but is also not expanding rapidly, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits is increasing by +5.83% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 58th percentile, indicating a moderate expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is present, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and support workforce growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 65 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. This suggests that homes are selling quickly, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, potentially affecting a business's ability to attract talent.

Office Economy

The city has an above-average share of professional and office workers, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which may require a different type of workforce.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a moderate labor market, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the weak labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth. Despite this, the city's affordable cost of living and expanding housing supply make it an attractive location for businesses looking to establish or expand operations.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

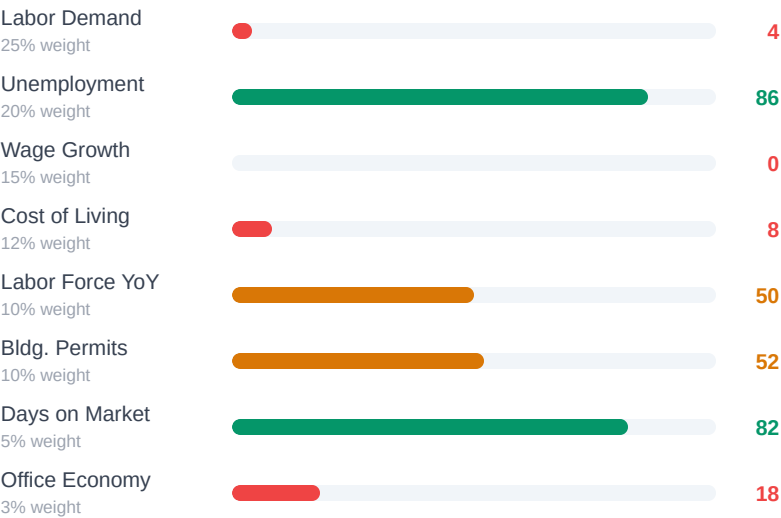
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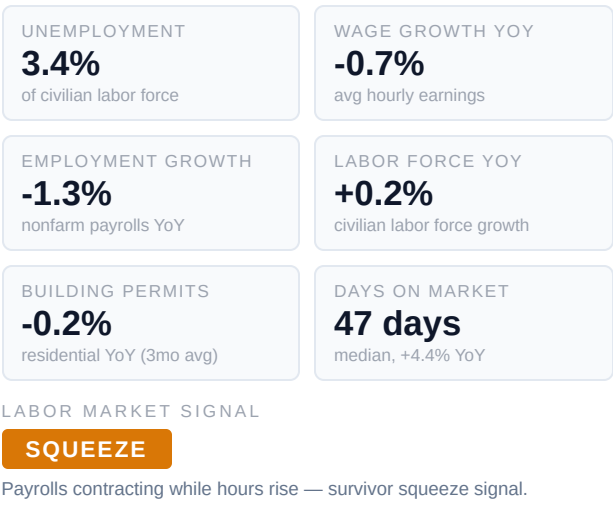
34.0th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34th out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, specifically a -1.33% employment growth rate and -0.71% year-over-year wage growth. The city's economic character is also marked by a tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.40%, and a relatively expensive cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.07. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The city's labor demand is characterized by a -1.33% employment growth rate and a +0.298% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours slightly above trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This metric ranks in the bottom tier, at the 4th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.40%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure and hiring challenges. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this city is -0.71%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing. The stagnant wage growth may make it difficult for businesses to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively expensive, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 5.07 and a percentile rank of 8, indicating that the city is less affordable compared to its peers. The PSF is \$166/sqft, which has increased by 4.4% year-over-year, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. This may put the city at a disadvantage in terms of talent attraction.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this city is growing at a rate of +0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding, providing a modest increase in hiring capacity for businesses. However, the slow

growth rate may not be sufficient to meet the demands of rapidly expanding companies.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has decreased by -0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. The slow growth in building permits may indicate a tightening housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this city is 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.4%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market may suggest a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests that the city has a less deep talent pool for tech, finance, and consulting businesses, making it less suited for companies that require specialized office workers. The city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with low unemployment, but also presents challenges such as stagnant wage growth, a relatively expensive cost of living, and a slow expansion of the labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining top talent due to the city's low affordability and stagnant wage growth, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to compete in the market.

Richmond

Richmond

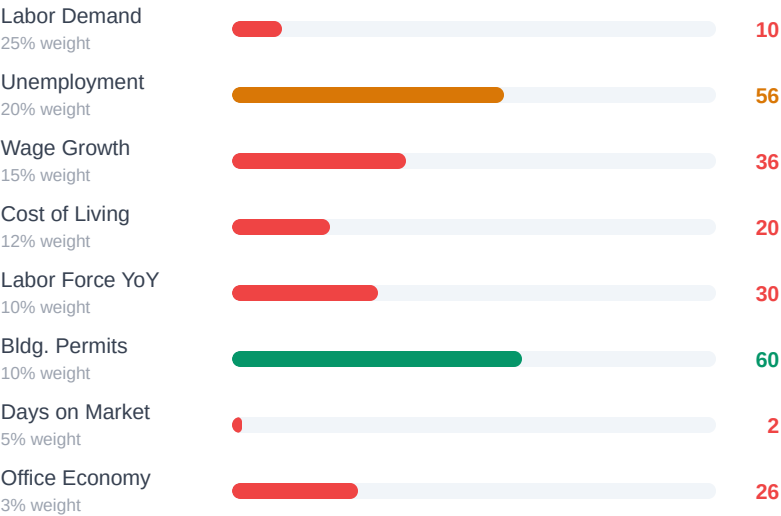
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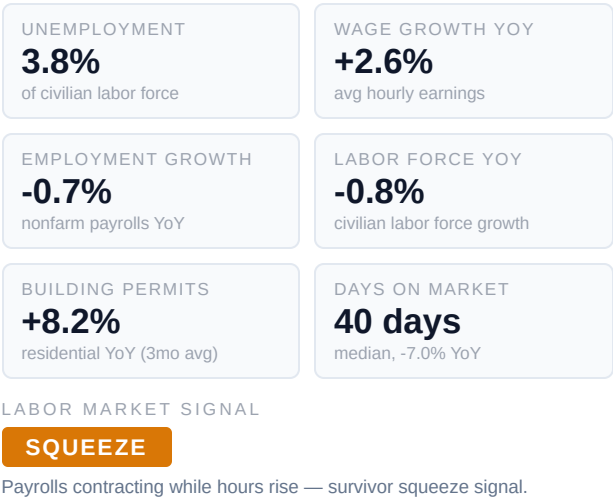
31.4th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, which ranks near the median at 56th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 3.05 and unemployment rate of 3.80% are key metrics that shape the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.72% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.245%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth, and the slight increase in hours worked may be due to a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in expanding their workforce in this market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, which is near the median, ranking at the 56th percentile. This indicates that the market has some slack, but it is not overly loose, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire new talent. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract workers in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.59%, which is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may impact businesses' decisions on staffing and compensation packages.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score that ranks at the 20th percentile, with a PSF of \$229/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.37, resulting in a ratio of 6.47. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is increasing by 1.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -0.80% year-over-year, indicating that the workforce supply is shrinking. This decline in labor force growth poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit new talent in this market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond is increasing by 8.22% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 60th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses in the long run.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is currently 40 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -7.0%. This rapid pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The low percentile rank of 2nd percentile further emphasizes the competitive nature of the market.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 26th percentile, with a composite score of 1.70. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

In conclusion, Richmond offers a mixed bag for businesses, with a tightening labor market and moderate wage growth, but also a relatively expensive cost of living and a competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and shrinking workforce supply, which may limit businesses' ability to expand and hire new talent in this market.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

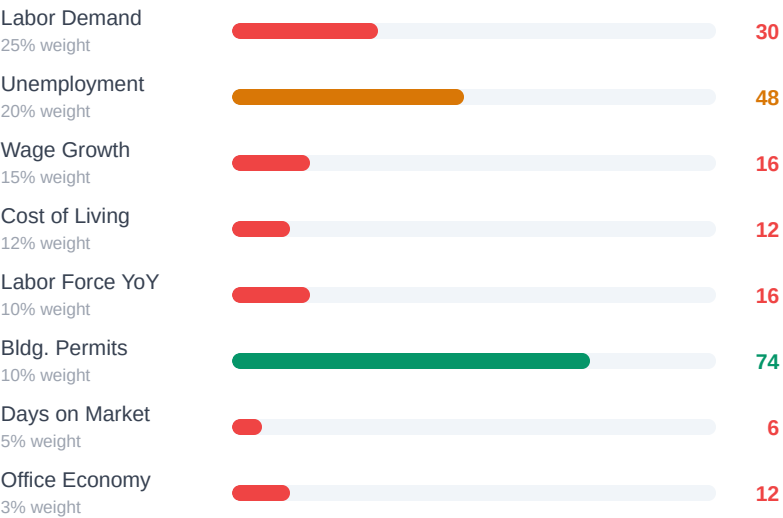
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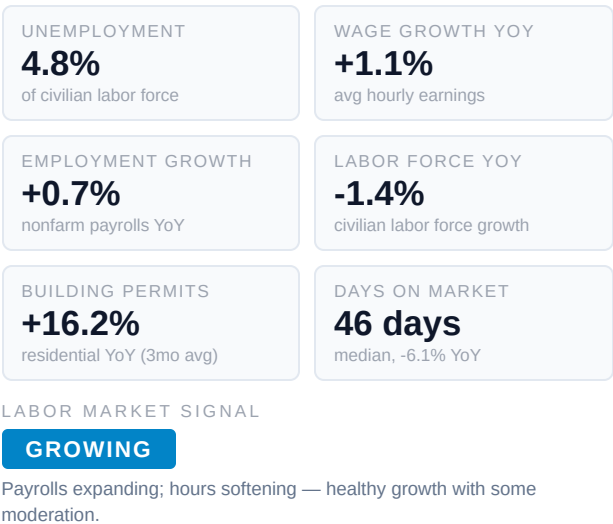
30.6th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, with a labor demand composite score of 4.38 and a wage growth rate of +1.15% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.69% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.889% below the city's own trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative hours deviation suggests that businesses may be absorbing the workload with existing staff rather than hiring new employees.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.80%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced market with some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the moderate unemployment rate may not provide enough downward pressure on wages to offset other costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.15%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals moderate labor costs for employers, but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant upward pressure on wages, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score ranking it in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, with a PSF-to-earnings ratio of \$344/sqft to \$37.97/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.06. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The slight increase in PSF of +0.3% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.39% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find qualified workers. The shrinking labor pool may limit the city's ability to support business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has increased by +16.17% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and accommodation for the workforce. The increase in building permits may help mitigate the city's affordability issues and support future business growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 46 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -6.1%. This rapid sales pace indicates a competitive market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low days on market may deter some businesses from locating in the area, as their employees may face difficulties in finding affordable and available housing.

Office Economy

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a professional and office worker share ranking it in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, with a composite score of 0.96. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. The city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a relatively balanced labor market and expanding housing supply, but its low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and high cost of living pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force, which may limit its ability to support business expansion and require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

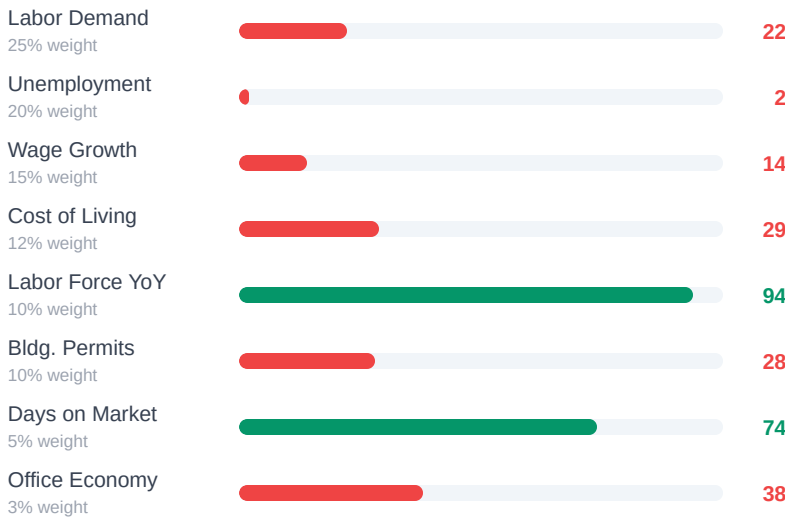
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CRITICAL

28.5th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.1%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+2.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-11.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days
median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 28.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.96, and its high unemployment rate of 5.40%, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.24% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.219% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be experiencing a period of job losses, which could lead to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.40%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a slack labor market with a significant amount of unemployment, making it easier for businesses to staff their operations. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.06%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This suggests stagnant wage growth, which means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly. However, this also implies weak bargaining power for workers, which could impact their purchasing power and overall economic well-being.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score that ranks at the 29th percentile, with a PSF of \$186/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.54/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.09. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising by +0.5% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +2.68% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This suggests that the labor force supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. This growth in labor force supply could provide a competitive advantage for companies looking to tap into a growing pool of workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is decreasing by -10.99% year-over-year, ranking below average. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.6%. This ranks in the above-average tier at the 74th percentile, indicating a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, this could be a competitive advantage, as they may have more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn ranks at the 38th percentile, with a composite score of 2.10. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a relatively slow housing market, which could provide a competitive advantage for companies looking to relocate or expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and high unemployment rate, which could impact local consumer demand and make it challenging to attract and retain top talent.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

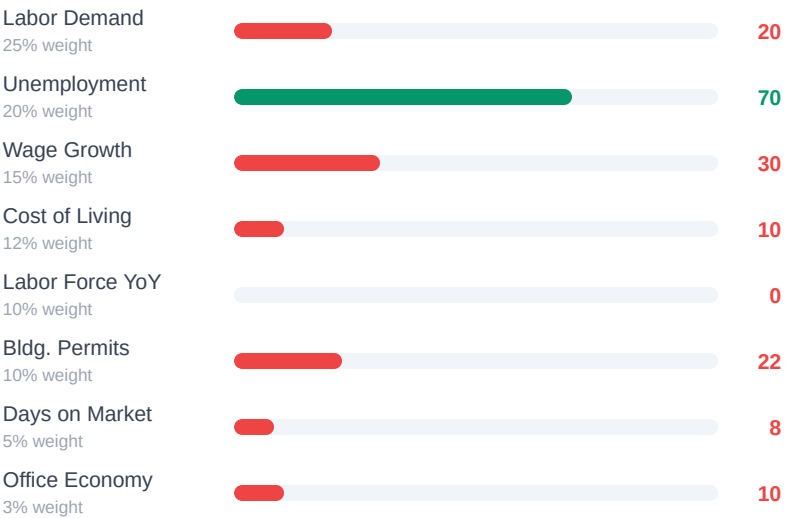
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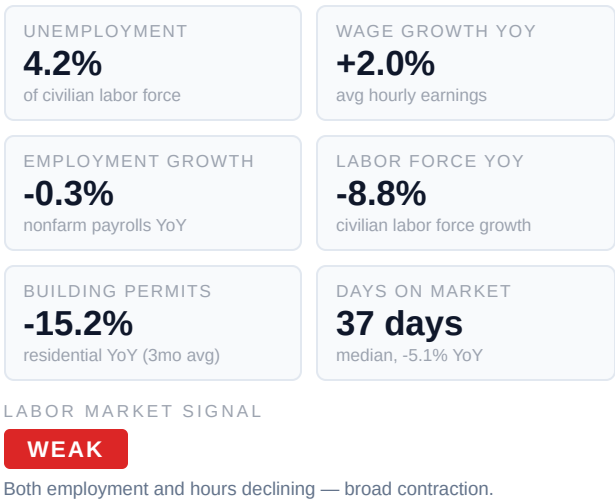
27.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 27.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 3.84, ranking it in the 20th percentile, and its cost of living ratio of 6.81, which places it in the 10th percentile for affordability. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.33% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.923% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a pace that would support genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be experiencing a period of payroll contraction.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.20%, which ranks it in the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a tight market, employers may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.03%, which is below average and ranks it in the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. However, it also indicates that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which could impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living ratio of 6.81, with a PSF of \$221/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.46/hr. The city's 10th percentile rank for affordability indicates that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living could be a deterrent for potential employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -8.76% year-over-year, which is the lowest rank among all metros. This significant decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find the workers they need to expand or maintain operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has decreased by -15.25% year-over-year. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -5.1%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing options.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 0.74, ranking it in the 10th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses that require specialized office or professional skills. As a result, the city may be better suited for industries that are less dependent on these types of workers, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area presents a challenging environment for businesses due to its low labor demand, tight labor market, and high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's declining labor force supply, which could limit the ability of businesses to hire and expand operations.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

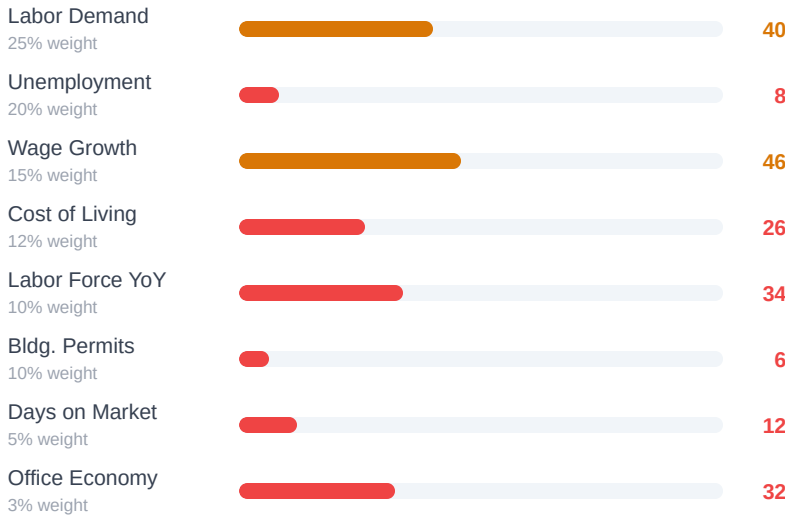
C-

CRITICAL

27.2th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.5%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-28.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

35 days

median, -2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 27.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 5.30% and its stagnant labor force growth rate of -0.53% YoY, indicating a tight labor market with limited workforce expansion. The labor demand composite score of 4.84, near the median, suggests a moderate level of job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.12% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.375% from the city's own trend signal a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a slow pace. This combination indicates that jobs are being added, and hours are running above trend, suggesting a moderate level of labor demand. However, the near-median percentile rank of 40th suggests that this demand is not exceptionally strong.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.30% is relatively high, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that they may have a larger pool of potential candidates to choose from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.22% is moderate, ranking at the 46th percentile. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not exceptionally fast, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a moderate pace. The implication for employer labor costs is that they will need to budget for moderate wage increases.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$221/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$37.09/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.96, ranks at the 26th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. However, the 2.8% YoY increase in PSF suggests that the city is becoming even less affordable. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's high cost of living may be a deterrent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.53% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the supply of workers is decreasing. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses may need to look outside the local labor market to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -28.57%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This decline signals that the city's housing market may become even tighter, leading to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation. The practical implication is that businesses may need to consider the potential impact on their employees' ability to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 35 days, with a YoY decrease of -2.8%, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. However, the low percentile rank of 12th suggests that homes are selling quickly, making it a competitive market for relocating workers. This means that workers may face challenges in finding and securing housing, which could impact their decision to relocate to the city.

Office Economy

The city's office economy, with a composite score of 1.92, ranks at the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies. On the other hand, the city may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting companies that require a highly specialized workforce.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a moderate level of labor demand and a relatively large pool of potential candidates due to its higher unemployment rate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the city's tight labor market and limited workforce expansion, which may lead to increased competition for talent and higher labor costs.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

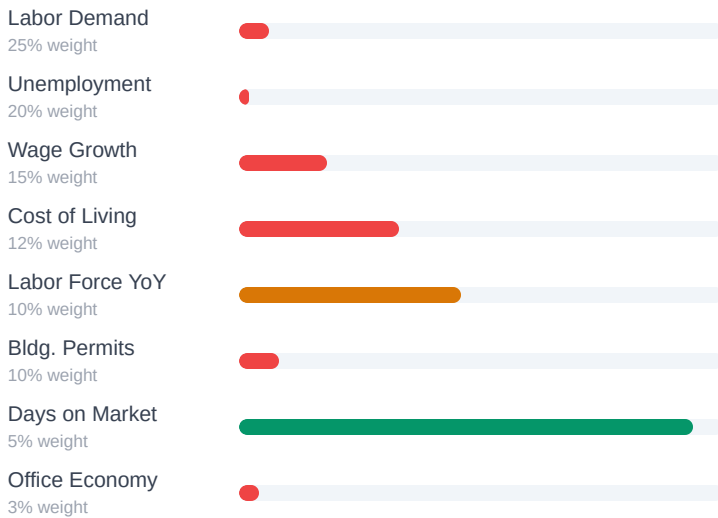
D

EMERGENCY

18.7th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-27.6%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

43 days
median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

4 Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 18.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.57. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with employment growth at -0.47% year-over-year, and its high unemployment rate of 5.20%, which is in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. These metrics signal significant challenges for businesses looking to hire and expand in the area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.47% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 1.071% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.57 is in the bottom tier, at the 6th percentile, indicating a weak job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 5.20%, which is in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a slack labor market, where businesses may find it easier to hire, but local consumer demand may be weaker. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this area is that they may have a larger pool of potential candidates to choose from, but may also face lower demand for their products or services.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.17%, which is in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This indicates moderate wage growth, which may lead to rising labor costs for employers, but also provides workers with some purchasing power. The implication for employer labor costs is that they may need to budget for modest wage increases, while workers may see some improvement in their standard of living.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Louisville-Jefferson County is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 33. The city has a PSF of \$178/sqft, which is 5.80 times the average hourly earnings of \$30.70/hr. This means that the city may have a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require wage premiums to afford the cost of living. The affordability of the city could be a draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is +0.08%, which is near the median at the 46th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is slowly expanding, which may provide businesses with a slightly larger pool of potential candidates to hire from. However, the slow growth rate may also indicate that the labor market is not particularly dynamic or attractive to new workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County is -27.55%, which is in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This indicates that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. The decline in building permits signals that developer confidence is low, and the city may struggle to provide enough housing for a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Louisville-Jefferson County is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%. This is in the top tier at the 94th percentile, indicating a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For a worker relocating to this city, the slower market may make it easier to find a home, but it also signals a lack of urgency and competition in the housing market.

Office Economy

The professional talent pool in Louisville-Jefferson County is relatively shallow, with an office economy percentile rank of 4. This indicates that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. The city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slow-growing labor force, but it also presents significant challenges, including low labor demand and a high unemployment rate. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the weak job market, which may limit the city's ability to attract and retain top talent, and ultimately hinder business growth and expansion.